

Jorge Luis Pando

2024 Curated Edition

The Effective Week

*Organized by Theme.
Packed with Strategy. Ready
for Action.*

Over the past year, many of you shared how helpful *The Effective Week* has been; but also mentioned how tough it can be to keep track of topics spread across weekly emails.

This curated edition is my way of fixing that: everything sorted by theme, so you can jump straight to what's most relevant.

As a small thank-you for referring someone to The Effective Collective, you're getting early access. I'll be doing one of these every year moving forward.

Appreciate you being here.



Jorge Luis Pando
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PRODUCTIVITY

Effective at Getting Things Done: The GOAT of Personal Productivity

When it comes to personal productivity, [Getting Things Done \(GTD\)](#) by David Allen is the go-to book. In my 14+ years in this space, nearly everyone I've met shares one thing in common: we've all read GTD multiple times and applied it in our lives.

GTD is essential, but like many frameworks, it's best to take it as a blueprint and then adapt it in a way that works for you. Today, let's explore the key takeaways so you can start implementing GTD today (while also being mindful of its downsides).

The Theory

The five steps of GTD. This framework is built on five steps that play a crucial role in staying organized and productive. Each step has even inspired other popular systems. Here's a breakdown:

Capture: "Your mind is for having ideas, not for holding them." GTD teaches us to capture everything (tasks, ideas, reminders) into a trusted system to free up mental space for higher-level thinking. This concept inspired frameworks like "[Building a Second Brain](#)" that go way deeper into the topic. Allen's "[mind like water](#)" principle emphasizes mental clarity, enabling us to respond fluidly to whatever comes our way.

Clarify: Once captured, decide if an item is actionable. Use the [two-minute rule](#): if it takes less than two minutes, do it now. In general, do one of the 4Ds - Delete it (if no action is required), Delegate it (if someone else is the right owner), Defer it (to Calendar or To-Do List), or Do it (If it takes less than 2 minutes).

Organize: Place tasks in categories. Organizing by context, priority, or deadline works well. This also applies to managing our inbox. GTD's foundation of the [Inbox Zero](#) and [task-batching](#) frameworks helps prevent emails from piling up.

Reflect: Regularly review to stay on track. Weekly reviews ensure tasks and goals are aligned. This step distinguishes GTD from a simple to-do list, helping us adapt to changing priorities. Systems like [journaling](#) also stem from this idea of combining task management with personal reflection.

Engage: Take action. With everything organized, focus on taking action. Trust this system, and let your *mind like water* guide you to the right tasks at the right time.

My Personal Thoughts

I love GTD's structure, but parts of it feel outdated. Allen emphasizes paper-based systems, filing documents, and printing things out, which doesn't align with today's digital world. These days, we rely on cloud storage and digital note-taking apps. [Side note: I can't help but think about all the trees involved in writing things on paper using the traditional GTD model!]

That said, GTD is still the G.O.A.T. In my 14+ years in productivity, every single expert I know started with GTD. Even with modern tools, the core principles still hold up because they're based on human psychology. I've adapted GTD to both Microsoft Outlook (and then I taught it to over 70 thousand people at Amazon) and now Gmail (I had my first presentation last week), and both work amazingly. [Side note: Want to know more about GTD in your inbox? Just hit reply, and I'll figure something out!]

How to Put This into Practice

Here's a simple guide to start implementing GTD:

1. **Capture everything.** Use the simplest notes app to write down every task, idea, or reminder. (e.g., I use Evernote.)
2. **Clarify the next action.** Ask yourself, "What's the next step?" Apply one of the 4Ds - Delete, Delegate (if someone else is the owner), Defer (to your calendar or To Do List), or Do It (if under two minutes).
3. **Organize by context.** Group tasks into a few simple categories (by action to be taken, by size, or by project tied to it)
4. **Reflect weekly.** Spend 30 minutes each week reviewing and re-prioritizing tasks to ensure focus on what matters.
5. **Engage in focused work.** Trust the system you just created and focus on your most important task.

To recap, many modern productivity concepts (*Building a Second Brain*, the *two-minute rule*, *Inbox Zero*, journaling, task-batching) can be traced back to GTD. If you want to master productivity, go to the source.

Running Effective Meetings: Do we really need them to begin with?

The other day someone told me "I want to be productive, but I can't because I have so many meetings." Well, guess what? Meetings should be a productive use of your time but organizations don't seem to be able to strike the right balance, either having too many or too few and not really driving any action with the ones they are having. Even after doing the deep dive I usually do when writing these articles, I am still not satisfied with what I have found. My preliminary conclusion is that there isn't a silver bullet and it is all about iterating to see what works best for your particular team and deliverables. Below you can find some interesting context and actionable recommendations.

*Side Note: A lot of you like commenting after reading these. If you hit reply to this email you can share your thoughts or (even better) you can open the online version and leave a comment for others to also benefit.

Effective Meetings

Ineffective meetings cost the US up to \$283 billion. Workers spend approximately 45% of their workweek (18 hours) preparing or attending status meetings. However, only 31% of meetings are considered necessary and workers don't feel comfortable declining meetings, with less than half people who feel like declining actually doing so (Source Otter.ai's meeting survey). Furthermore, according to Microsoft Team's data, the most popular times for meetings are 9-11am and 2-3pm, which is also an issue as it conflicts with people's [most popular productive time](#) of the day.

Data shows the best companies have more meetings. With Slack, email, and meetings, and people not using them effectively, productivity suffers. Workers face an average of 13.9 daily interruptions from collaboration tools, taking 20 minutes to regain focus. Employees spend half their time collaborating, but the distinction lies in direct (meetings/phone calls) vs. asynchronous (emails) interactions, with simple companies favoring the former by 7%, as per [BCG's study of 1,000 global companies](#), proving the real power of meetings when done right.

Predictable, repetitive meetings are a big piece of the pie. According to [Doodle's State of meetings report 2023](#), in the US, 22% of meetings are scheduled a month in advance (in Europe this is up to 46%!). Let's assume that in the majority of the examples are due to how predictably cyclical our work is. This immediately makes me think about EOS's (Entrepreneurial Operating System) Level 10 meetings. The name "Level 10" encapsulates the aspiration for perfection, scoring a perfect 10 on the productivity scale. At its core, a Level 10 meeting follows a structured agenda, encompassing discussions on crucial metrics, issue resolution, and a review of commitments made in the preceding week. [Details here](#).

Extreme problems require extreme solutions: Shopify's meeting exodus.

Shopify's radical move to delete 322,000 hours of meetings has sent ripples of envy through corporate America. They created a custom-coded bot to delete recurring meetings involving three or more people, and to highlight the cost of a new meeting based on the salary of people invited. The purge aimed at boosting productivity has garnered widespread positive feedback. Shopify saw that employees now empowered to decline meetings, even from senior managers. While meetings aren't extinct, Shopify's approach highlights a trend towards reevaluating the necessity of endless virtual gatherings, inspiring other companies to rethink their meeting culture, some even allotting a number of meeting minutes per employee.

Tips for more productive meetings:

1. **Set team norms around communication:** It is crucial for your team to understand what is the SLA for every method of communication and when should each be used. For instance, Slack is for requests that take less than 2 minutes (popular [GTD principle](#)) and should be answered to by EOD, encourage people to decline a meeting without a clear agenda or with several people from their same team.
2. **Set a clear structure to the meeting:** Start with the purpose of the meeting and then work backwards from that purpose with proposed discussion topics.
3. **Reduce the number of people you invite:** Share the agenda ahead of time and only invite one person per team. Tell those people to forward the meeting if necessary, based on the agenda, but start small to begin with. Another solution for long meetings is to only invite people to the part of the meeting that is relevant to them.
4. **Give a sense of continuity to your recurrent meetings:** Always start a recurrent meeting (e.g. weekly business review, bi-weekly team meeting, monthly sync with your mentor) with what was left as a next step from last time and what the current status is, then build on top of that.
5. **Stop 5 minutes before the end to recap and distribute notes:** Many meetings end without a real conclusion and people forget to follow through. End you meetings by recapping and sending a note with agreements, next steps, owners, due date.
6. **Be savvy about meeting-time management:** As soon as you see the discussion going into a tangent, take a next step and force the conversation to continue as you planned.
7. **Evaluate Office Hour-type meetings:** If you have too many meetings, evaluate setting Office Hours and pushing all the conversation to a specific time of the day as opposed to at any time during the entire day.

An Effective Prioritization Framework: The Life Jar Theory

If you are reading this, you probably juggle too many things at once. I don't want to spoil it to you all, but it just keeps getting more and more challenging. I remember complaining about how hard it was for my family to juggle two jobs and a kid and other older/wiser people would tell me "oh, and wait until you have 2" or "waiting until they go to school." The truth is that prioritization is key to work and key to life in general. Below, I am sharing the best prioritization framework I know, hoping you can keep this analogy when reviewing your own Life Priorities

What's the theory behind?

The Life Jar Theory is about putting the big rocks first. Stephen Covey popularized this theory in his famous book "[First Things First](#)" (which also massified the concept of the Eisenhower matrix... but that's another post). Covey encourages us to imagine our time and energy like a jar, and the big rocks are our main priorities (family, health, career, etc.). Then, there's also pebbles, sand, and water, representing all the other stuff that usually fills our time (emails, household chores, social media, etc.). The learning here is that we need to put the big rocks in first, then fit in the smaller stuff around them. Otherwise, if you fill the jar with pebbles, sand or water before the rocks, then those won't fit, leaving behind important things.

The Life Jar Theory highlights an essential truth: there's always room for more, even when it seems like there isn't. Expanding on Covey's insights, [a professor demonstrates](#) by filling a jar with golf balls, representing the big rocks of life. Initially, the class views it as full. Yet, as the professor adds pebbles, sand, and even beer, and the jar accommodates more than expected. The profound lesson? While prioritizing the big rocks is crucial, the jar of life is far from full. It's a reminder that even in life's apparent fullness after putting the golf balls (big rocks), there's always space for other activities and joys, like sharing a couple of beers with friends.



How to use the Life Jar Theory?

1. **Starting superficial:** If you follow what this theory recommends, you might end up identifying Big Rocks such as "Family," "Work," "Health," etc. Although this is a good starting point, I do think you can go deeper than that
2. **Choose 5 Big Rocks but frame them as SMART Goals** (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-Based). So instead of your big rock being "Health," or "Family," you will have big rocks such as "Exercise 4 times a week," or "Sit down for a electronics-free family dinner 5 times a week".
3. **Do the same but for work - Determine 5 Big Rocks:** Make one of your Rocks focused on developing yourself (and your org). This might be something like "get X hours of training every quarter".
4. **Do an audit for your time and your money.** Now that you have your 5 Big Rocks, assess how much of your current time and your current money is spent on each. This way, you can unveil any misalignments. For instance, you might say that Self-development is important and have taken no training so far this year, or say that your priority is to be healthy and exercise 4 times a week, but don't want to spend any money on a trainer or nutrition program.

My personal thoughts - Sharing my two cents:

First, sometimes the rocks conflict each other. For instance, if you want to spend quality time with your kids and also want to be the CEO of a big corporation, or you want to eat healthy, but you pick a job that requires a lot of travelling and eating out. Those might conflict. The truth is that sometimes we go through life on auto-pilot and we don't really audit our decisions based on what we deem are our Big Rocks. We SAY that we care about one thing and then end up making a life decision (job, career, spouse) that doesn't really let us do what we want to. Whatever you decide, do so intentionally.

Second, our jars cannot solely have Rocks, we need room for pebbles and sand too. I know the whole "hustle culture" is demonizing everything that is not a core priority. But, you know what? It is OK for our Jars to feel imbalanced for a given period of our lives (working too late, or partying too hard). The key is that we do so intentionally and try not to create a conflict with another one of your big priorities. Our Jars shouldn't be audited daily or weekly, I believe it is all about zooming out and having a balanced Jar in the long-run (like the image below suggests).

Effectively Differentiating Urgent vs. Important: Why the Eisenhower Matrix Falls Short in Corporate Reality

As I mentioned in [The Life Jar Theory](#), Stephen Covey also brought the concept of the Eisenhower Matrix to the masses. This matrix is great, but I do think it is a bit detached from how things really work in a corporate setting. So let me briefly explain the theory, and then share what I have seen helps many others when trying to put it in practice.

What's the theory behind?

The Eisenhower Matrix originates as a framework to effectively prioritize tasks and critical decisions. Although the exact year isn't confirmed, the story dates back to when Dwight Eisenhower was Supreme Commander of the Allied Expeditionary Force during World War II, before becoming the 34th President of the United States. Fifty years later, Stephen Covey scaled this concept by recommending to implement it in a corporate setting.

The Matrix categorizes tasks into [four Quadrants \(Q\)](#):

Q1 - Do (Urgent and Important): Tasks requiring immediate attention and that are aligned to your goals (e.g. upcoming deadlines or house of fires).

Q2 - Schedule (Important, but Not Urgent): Tasks that are aligned to your goals, but if you don't do something now, nothing really happens. So, you need to schedule them for a later date. (e.g. your own personal development).

Q3 - Delegate (Urgent, but Not Important) Tasks that demand immediate action, but are not aligned to your goals so you should be thinking about saying "no" to or delegating to someone else (e.g. when others interrupt you because they need your help).

Q4 - Delete (Not Urgent and Not Important): Tasks that are neither aligned to your goals nor time sensitive that you should be just eliminating all together (e.g. those intriguing [BuzzFeed questionnaires](#)).

How to use this framework in theory? (The blue pill)

The main learning here is that we usually mistake Urgent for Important. We should be aiming towards tackling the Q1s first, spend the majority of our time on Q2s, and remove Q3s and Q4s from our task lists.

- **Step 1: Place your tasks into Quadrants.** Start by listing all your tasks and give each an Urgent and an Important score from 1 to 5 (lowest to highest).
- **Step 2: Prioritize Q1 first.** Focus on getting them out of the way first.

- **Step 3: Allocate time for Q2.** Go to your calendar and schedule time when you will address them. Aim for the majority of your time to be spent in Q2.
- **Step 4: Ruthlessly eliminate (delegate or delete) Q3 and Q4.** Avoid focusing on them at all cost.
- **Step 5: Regularly audit and adjust.**

My personal thoughts (The Red Pill)

Although the recommendations from this matrix are good on paper, my personal view is that they are kind of idealistic, and out of touch with corporate reality. So, building on top of the existing theory, here is my adaptation based from decades of implementation (for self and others):

- **Step 6: Get yourself out of the Q1 quicksand.** There's a chance you will get more Q1 tasks non-stop and never get the chance to move to Q2. So, you need to address the issue from the root. Two ways I recommend: (1) Build [Team Communication Norms](#); and (2) Scrutinize every new Q1 that gets to your plate by politely [asking "why" several times](#), you will likely realize that the urgent part of the task is way smaller than what it initially was.
- **Step 7: Trick your brain into believes Q2s are actually Q1s.** Although Q2 tasks are important, they are relatively easy to procrastinate. As Tim Urban's famously illustrated, deadlines are like monsters that [scare off the instant gratification monkeys](#) in our brains. So it is important to see fake deadlines for Q2 items. For instance, if you want to read more but can't seem to prioritize it, join a book club.
- **Step 8: You need to do Q3s for the sake of teamwork.** It is really unrealistic to think that you'll go: "No, Bob from marketing, I won't help you with your presentation because it is not a goal of mine". We are all working as a team here, so you will sometimes need to work on things that are urgent and important to others. The important here is that you: (1) Do spend a limited percentage of your time here; and (2) You give visibility to your leadership that you have contributed. The risk with spending too much time in Q3 is that you become a "people pleaser" and you don't advance towards your own goals, but hey, there's a chance that you'll need Bob from Marketing's help at some point, right?
- **Step 9: Put a timer to your Q4 tasks:** It is unrealistic to think that during work hours we won't do a Wordle, or catch on the news, or play that [funny Tiktok](#) everyone in our group chat is reacting to...just remember to enjoy that for a controlled amount of time. As soon as the timer hits, put the phone down, and go back to work feeling refreshed!

So, do you want to take the [blue pill or the red pill](#)?

Effective at Time-Boxing: The #1 Productivity Hack

I recently revisited [this article](#) with a curated list of the "Definitive 100 Most Useful Productivity Tips", and I agree almost entirely with it. I have talked about some of these topics before (saying no, prioritizing, etc.), but in the upcoming weeks I will try to give my take on at least the top 10. It is no surprise that "time boxing" tops the list, so this will be the focus of today.

The Theory

Timeboxing involves dedicating fixed periods of time to single tasks. It originated in 1991 from the Agile software development book [Rapid Application Development](#) (a software development technique now part of the Agile family), where time is divided into sprints. Timeboxing enhances focus by minimizing distractions and dedicating specific slots to tasks (no wonder it became so popular for personal development).

Timeboxing's key benefits are combating Parkinson's Law and promoting single-tasking. [Parkinson's Law](#) states that "work expands to fill the time available for its completion." By assigning strict time limits, work is completed more efficiently. Timeboxing also breaks large projects into manageable chunks, reducing overwhelm and providing a sense of accomplishment. [side note: I cringe every time I hear someone say that they are "good multitaskers." There are very rare occasions when it is good to multitask; work isn't one of them].

The "[Planning Fallacy](#)" is the great challenge timeboxing faces. We have a tendency to underestimate task completion times. We often fail to account for unexpected interruptions or our natural cycles, which don't allow us to work steadily for 8 hours straight.

My personal thoughts

You need to understand what works for you. I've tried [The Pomodoro Technique](#) over many other frameworks, but found 45-minute work blocks with 5-minute breaks suit me best. Constantly try new approaches, reflect, and iterate.

Task batching is a good complement to timeboxing. We all have busy lives, and I personally tend to push aside the things that are easy and take a really short time, until they are urgent and so I do them quickly. Now, I complement timeboxing with task batching for quick tasks like scheduling appointments or expense reports. Grouping these during lower-energy periods provides a gratifying sense of accomplishment.

How to put this into practice

Cal Newport recommends aiming for [3-4 hours of uninterrupted daily work](#). My recommendation is to start with 90min and then double once you are ready. Here's how to get started:

1. **Identify Your Daily Highlight:** As suggested in "[Make Time](#)," choose one critical task to prioritize every workday, and focus your 90 minutes on it. Do this early in the morning or the night before.
2. **Schedule the Time Block:** Allocate a specific 90-minute window that matches your peak energy level (according to [your chronotype](#)). This is at 10-11:30am for the majority of us. Other options are early morning (for early birds) or later at night (for the night owls).
3. **Eliminate Distractions:** During your time block, turn off notifications, close unnecessary tabs, and inform peers that you are unavailable.
4. **Use a Timer:** I use this [simple timer](#) with two blocks of 45 minutes (separated by a 5-minute break). Seeing time running out motivates me to refocus when distracted.
5. **Review and Adjust:** Evaluate your progress afterwards. If more/less time was needed, adjust future blocks accordingly through this continuous improvement process.

Mastering timeboxing takes practice, but the productivity gains are immense. Start with 45 minutes if 90 is too daunting initially, but work your way up to three focused hours daily. It's challenging but rewarding - give it a dedicated try!

Effective at Taking Breaks: How to Know When Best to Come Out for Air

The theory

We can't talk about this topic without starting with Pomodoro. The [Pomodoro Technique](#) encourages productivity through structured cycles of work and breaks. Created in the late 1980s, this time management method involves working for 25 minutes (a "Pomodoro") followed by a 5-minute break, with a longer break of 15-30 minutes after four Pomodoros. This technique creates a sense of urgency and reduces mental fatigue, and overcome procrastination by breaking work into manageable chunks.

The 90-Minute Work Cycle leverages natural body rhythms to boost productivity.

Based on the biological phenomenon of [ultradian rhythms](#), which are the daily natural cycles in our bodies that affect our energy levels, this method involves working for about 90 minutes followed by a 15-20 minute break. This technique works by aligning work habits with these rhythms, working during periods of high energy and taking breaks during low points. It gained popularity from its appearance in the book ["The Way We're Working Isn't Working."](#)

The 52-17 Rule optimizes productivity by balancing intense work periods with short breaks. The productivity app DeskTime did [a study on productive employees](#) and concluded the "Effective Breaking" is the number one secret to productivity. They noticed that on average the most productive people work intensively for about an hour and then needed a short break, which led them to popularize the concept of working for 52 minutes followed by a 17-minute break to re-charge, avoiding burnout, and sustain energy and focus. DeskTime emphasizes that the best breaks involve moving away from the computer or cellphone.

My personal thoughts

While planning my week, I try to avoid 30-minute open slots. I noticed that, at work, I was usually getting 30-minute free slots, and I realized they were the worst. I noticed that I could do a lot in an hour or I had no problem jumping from one meeting to another, but those 30-minute slots were a weird in-between where I either ended up reading emails mindlessly or taking a longer break than needed. I learned to try to reschedule meetings to avoid these when planning my week or have a list of small tasks (paying a bill, scheduling an appointment) to fill that space.

I love the concept of breaking the day into 90-minute chunks. There are roughly 10 of these 90-minute blocks in a given day. I noticed that my worst self was when I tried to have different mindsets during the same time block. Now, I can remain focused for 90 minutes because I have done it all my life while watching movies, so I apply the same principle. My core blocks are: (1) Family Mode (7-8:30 am and 5:30-7 pm): I try my best to be away from my phone and focus on family. (2) Deep Work Mode (10-11:30 am and 2:30-4 pm). My peak energy times, when I avoid meetings and do the most challenging tasks. I don't go for 90 minutes straight but do two blocks of 40-45 minutes with a 5-10 minute break. (3) Exercise Time (11:30 am-1 pm). I exercise/walk/stretch and have lunch.

How to Put This Into Practice

To insert an effective break strategy into your routine, follow these steps:

1. **Try Different Techniques:** Test Pomodoro, the 90-Minute Work Cycle, and the 52-17 Rule for a week each. Note which method suits your energy levels and productivity best.
2. **Schedule Breaks:** Each week, use calendar reminders or apps to schedule your work and breaks. Treat these breaks as essential to ensure consistency.
3. **Choose Break Activities Wisely:** Plan productive break activities that involve getting away from your screen such as stretching, walking, or talking to peers. Avoid dopamine-filled activities like social media.
4. **Review and Adjust:** Reflect on what is working and what isn't. Similar to what I did to find my optimal times, try to adjust your routine and break activities as needed.

Remember the goal is to have three hours of productive work time, that can be split however best suits you and with many breaks you need, just find your balance. You might not reach this goal every single day, and that is OK, trying is the most important.

Effective means doing fewer things: Prioritizing the most important

I just celebrated my first 4th of July as an American Citizen (I shared my key learnings [here](#)) with family, friends, BBQ, and fireworks...it doesn't get better than this. Today, I also decided to take the day off to celebrate by watching three Euro and Copa America matches, cleaning my garage, and doing my Quarterly Finances. Talk about being effective.

Having already discussed most of the Top 5 items from [this article](#), I want to focus below on something that is essential for feeling in control of our workloads: prioritization.

The Theory

Deciding what to do vs. deciding when to do it. I've previously discussed popular frameworks that focus on deciding what to do, like the [Eisenhower Matrix](#) and [The Big Rocks \(Jar\) Theory](#). Today, I want to explore the concept of knowing when to do it, focusing on "less is more," emphasizing doing fewer but more impactful tasks. Examples include Most Important Task (MIT), Eat That Frog, and the Ivy Lee Method. These methods focus on a limited number of high-impact tasks each day to ensure our most important work gets done. Let's take a closer look at each.

The [Most Important Task \(MIT\)](#) framework involves identifying the single most important task for the day. By highlighting the task that will have the greatest impact on our goals, we ensure that our highest priority is addressed first. This approach helps to eliminate distractions and maintain focus on what truly matters. Every day should have an MIT.

The [Eat That Frog](#) method encourages tackling the most challenging and important task first thing in the morning. This technique ensures that we handle our toughest task when our energy is at its peak, setting a productive tone for the rest of the day. It's worth mentioning that if you are a [Night Owl](#), you probably don't want to do this first thing, but wait until your energy peak time.

The [Ivy Lee Method](#) involves writing down the six most important tasks to accomplish each day and prioritizing them in order of importance. At the end of each workday, we should list our top six tasks for the next day. When the new day begins, start with the first task and work on it until it's complete before moving on to the next. It's that simple.

My personal Thoughts

The key is to find out what works for us. These methods share many similarities, so I mention them together. Use them as references to find your optimal approach, whether that involves one task or six. Ultimately, the goal is to focus on fewer tasks one at a time.

Focus on tasks, not projects. Treating projects as tasks can lead to getting stuck and becoming demotivated. "Break down the lion into small kittens" ([here's how](#)).

How to determine the most important tasks? That's where the other frameworks, like the [Eisenhower Matrix](#) and [The Big Rocks \(Jar\) Theory](#), come in handy.

How to Put This Into Practice

To implement the "less is more" concept, combine the best elements of these three models.

1. **End your day by listing your six most important tasks for the next day** (Ivy Lee Method).
2. **Identify the single Most Important Task from this list** (MIT + Eisenhower).
3. **Start your day by tackling this important task first** (Eat That Frog). If you're not a morning person, cover this when you have the most energy (usually around 10 am).
4. **Work through the rest of your list in order of importance.** Only move on to the next task once the current one is complete.
5. **Review and adjust your task list daily.** Ensure that you continuously focus on high-impact tasks and adapt as needed.

By integrating these strategies, you can enhance your productivity, manage your workload more effectively, and truly embrace the "less is more" philosophy.

Effective at Eliminating External Distractors: Master Focus in a connected world

Last week brought a couple of significant events. First, while I'll avoid political commentary, the recent news from the US presidential race reminded me of the challenge of knowing when to quit. Sometimes, stepping aside is the best decision for ourselves and those who rely on our leadership (I wrote about it [here](#).)

On a personal note, after two months of self-employment, I noticed how much more I was using my phone. With fewer meetings, I found myself increasingly distracted by WhatsApp, social media, and endless videos (all supposedly about "improving soft skills"). I tried various strategies to offset this, but one approach has proven effective over the past month. Knowing I was going to write about distractions, I reached out to [the company behind it](#), and they offered the promo code "effective" for a 10% discount. I know it's a small discount, but I'm excited because this is a first for me. I don't really see this newsletter pushing ads any time soon; however, depending on how this goes, I will continue to reach out proactively to brands I trust, and provide something valuable to you all. So if you want more of these, keep reading to see if you can benefit from this solution.

The Theory

In today's connected world, email, messaging apps, and phones are the top non-physical distractions impacting our productivity. Evidence shows that the average office worker receives about 121 emails daily and engages in up to 6.2 hours of digital communication. This explains why we sometimes feel we aren't accomplishing much during work hours (I wrote a whole post about this [here](#)). And then there's our phones - an omnipresent source of distraction. On average, Americans check their phones [96 times a day](#), spending approximately 5 hours and 24 minutes daily. [Side note: If these stats don't make you want to keep reading, I'm not sure what will.]

Cal Newport's "Deep Work", explains that constant email and messaging keep us in a state of "shallow work," reducing our ability to focus deeply due to a "task-shifting penalty." Research supports this: a study from the University of Irvine found that it takes 20 minutes to regain momentum after an interruption, while a [University of London study](#) showed that just being interrupted by an email notification can lower IQ by as many as 10 points. This second study is even titled "Emails Hurt IQ More Than Pot," which I think only highlights the point I'm making.

Phones are perhaps the biggest offenders. They're designed to grab our attention with endless notifications and updates. The dopamine rush from these interactions creates a feedback loop that makes us "want more," leading to significant distraction... and even addiction. Many experts recommend curing this addiction by using strategies like switching your phone to greyscale mode (to reduce its visual

appeal) or using apps to block distracting content. These methods help in managing phone use and maintaining focus.

My Personal Thoughts

I read multiple times online that "airplane mode is the ultimate productivity hack" - no notifications, no distractions, just focus. However, I found that completely disconnecting from my phone all day wasn't realistic. [Side Note: Like many other online recommendations, I wonder if those posting them actually try their own "hacks"]. I also tried the app-blocking feature on my iPhone. It worked initially but became ineffective once my brain got used to bypassing it (with just 4 magical digits!).

That's when I tried Brick (getbrick.app/shop), which truly worked for me. Brick helps you stay focused by blocking distracting apps in a customizable way.

Unlike generic advice like airplane mode, Brick allowed me to have different settings, for example: I have one for workouts (blocking most apps but allowing YouTube and Spotify) and another for deep work (blocking everything but phone calls and text messages). This approach has worked well for me as I strive to get at least 3 hours of deep work per day. However, the key is experimenting to find what suits you best. **If you also think your phone is absorbing a lot of your time and want to give Brick a try, use the code "[effective](#)" for a 10% discount.**

How to Put This Into Practice

1. **Remove Email Notifications:** Go to your email provider and disable popup notifications ([here](#) is an example of how to do it for Outlook; you can easily Google how to do it for others). If you think that this is not feasible because you need to respond to emails immediately, try to still do this but check email every hour for 10 minutes. This will allow you to have at least 50 minutes of deep work in between.
2. **Switch Your Phone to Greyscale:** On an iPhone, go to Settings > Accessibility > Display and Text Size > Color Filters, turn "Color Filters" on, and select "Greyscale."
3. **Block Distracting Apps:** Use airplane mode or the screen time features on your phone (iPhone has downtime and app limits). For a more personalized solution, try using an app like [Brick](#) to customize how to block access to the distracting apps that are relevant.
4. **Allow Specific Screen-Time:** Allocate specific times during the day to check your phone and stick to them. This prevents constant checking and helps you stay focused during work periods.

Effective Delegation: About Trust, Control, and Empowerment

Three months into being a "solopreneur," one of the hardest challenges has been the lack of delegation. I once aimed to master the "art of delegation," and as I revisit this topic, I thought it would be beneficial to share my insights with you.

Delegation isn't just for managers. Everyone on multidisciplinary teams delegates tasks - down, up, or sideways. When you see the word "leader" as you continue reading this, remember this could mean leading a project, not just a team. Even for those without manager roles, effective delegation is crucial.

The Theory

Delegation Poker is a great framework to clarify decision-making in teams.

[Management 3.0](#) breaks down delegation into seven levels (from least to most):

1. **Tell:** The leader decides and informs the team. Best for urgent or critical tasks.
2. **Sell:** The leader decides but explains the reasoning to gain buy-in and support.
3. **Consult:** The leader seeks input before deciding, considering the team's perspectives.
4. **Agree:** The decision is made jointly with the team, fostering collaboration and sense of ownership.
5. **Advise:** The team decides with the leader offering guidance. A good way to mentor while still giving the team control.
6. **Inquire:** The team decides, and the leader is informed afterward. Best for teams with expertise and autonomy, with leaders who still want to be "kept in the loop."
7. **Delegate:** The team has full authority to decide and execute without the leader's involvement. The ultimate level of trust and empowerment.

[Side note: This framework reminds me of [Situational Leadership](#), which also emphasizes adapting leadership style based on the situation. Maybe this is a topic for another post.]

CTD's "[Waiting For](#)" concept is great for managing delegated tasks. How to do this? Set up a "Waiting For" folder in your inbox, create a rule for emails from yourself to go there, and BCC yourself when delegating. Review the folder regularly (1 - 5 times a week) to ensure a timely follow-up.

My Personal Thoughts

Finding Win-Wins. At Amazon, I learned that delegation isn't just about offloading tasks; it's about empowering people. Everyone is "busy," so delegating might seem impossible. To delegate effectively, understand and align tasks with team members' passions and aspirations. This will lead to motivated team members and better outcomes. Yes, it may take them longer, but their extra motivation compensates.

Force yourself to move up from "Tell". For instance, in "goal setting," even if you're clear on goals, involving the team boosts morale and ownership (moving from "Tell" to "Agree"). This worked well with my direct reports and cross-functional partners, making the goals truly "ours" and not just "mine." As a business leader, including other functions (e.g. tech, finance) in goal-setting has been rewarding for them and insightful for me.

Automation is a form of delegation, especially for [high-frequency, low-complexity](#) tasks. Leaders should consider automating these tasks to free up time and improve efficiency. Do you know what percentage of your time is spent on such tasks?

Actionable Next Steps

1. **Identify a Task:** Choose a task to delegate this week, ideally one that doesn't align well with your current strengths or responsibilities.
2. **Identify Candidates:** Take time to learn about team members' development goals to find a win-win.
3. **(If no win-win) Discuss with Your Manager:** Justify offloading a task by explaining how it benefits the team (i.e. what new task will you take on and what results will you bring). Consider automating as a solution.
4. **Use Delegation Poker:** Assess your team's workload across the seven levels. Aim for a healthy distribution of: 25% Tell/Sell, 35% Consult/Agree, 25% Advise/Inquire, and 15% Delegate (adjust based on team's seniority)
5. **Leverage the "Waiting For" List:** Implement the GTD's concept to track delegated tasks without micromanaging.

Delegation, whether to people or processes, is about working smarter. Regularly audit your Delegation Poker levels to keep your team motivated and projects moving forward.

Effective in Eliminating Internal Distractors: Managing Your Wandering Mind

A few weeks ago, I wrote about [eliminating external distractors](#). I used this word intentionally because, even if we manage to tame the 6.2 hours spent on emails and direct messages, **internal** distractions still need attention. A quick disclaimer: while meditation is an excellent solution to this, it's not my area of expertise. So, this text focuses on tactical ways to manage internal distractions, not necessarily eliminate them. If you're an expert in meditation and want to contribute, I'd be happy to connect.

Still not sure what **internal** distractions are? Keep reading...

Theory

"A human mind is a [wandering mind](#), and a wandering mind is an unhappy mind." A Harvard study found that people's minds wander nearly 47% of the time and this mind-wandering is strongly linked to unhappiness. Staying present and focused not only improves productivity but also enhances emotional well-being. Training ourselves to focus reduces cognitive overload and boosts overall satisfaction.

Clearing your mind of unprocessed thoughts can drastically reduce internal distractions. David Allen's *Getting Things Done* (GTD) methodology introduces the concept of "mind like water," where your mental state remains calm and focused, able to respond freely without being burdened by unresolved tasks. Capturing everything externally (whether through written notes or apps) frees our mind to focus on the task at hand, allowing it to function optimally.

Now everyone wants to build a "second brain." This concept, popularized by Tiago Forte, focuses on building a reliable (and robust) digital system to store information, tasks, and ideas. This external system helps unclutter our mind, leaving it to focus on higher-order thinking. This practice is referred to as Personal Knowledge Management (PKM), and it allows knowledge workers to handle large amounts of information without mental overload. [Side Note: After a long exploration, I ended up coming up with my own version of this, not following any of the popular frameworks. I suggest everyone finds what works best for them to capture digitally all the content they are consuming].

[External pacts](#), as suggested by Nir Eyal in [Indistractable](#), are commitments you make with others to stay accountable and avoid distractions. These pacts leverage social pressure to keep you focused. By creating boundaries in advance and involving others (e.g. sharing your work plans with colleagues or setting deadlines), we reduce the likelihood of giving in to distractions, making it easier to stay on task and achieve your objectives.

My Own Personal Thoughts

One technique I use to manage internal distractions is sending myself emails when an idea or request comes up.

As soon as a thought enters my mind or someone asks me for something, I email it to myself. This ensures I don't forget and prevents the thought from lingering and distracting me from current tasks. It's a quick way to clear my mind. Instead of mentally juggling the idea, I know it's documented for later. [Side Note: My wife used to find it weird when I asked her to "email me" things while I was driving, but now, she does it too!]

HOW TO PUT THIS INTO PRACTICE

1. **Create a reliable external system for capturing thoughts.** Whether you use a notebook, a note-taking app, or send emails to yourself, ensure that every new task or idea is immediately documented. This will free up mental space for more important work.
2. **Set deadlines as external commitments:** Share your tasks with a colleague, partner, or supervisor to create accountability. Create a deadline even if one doesn't exist (e.g. to deliver the structure of a document you will take two weeks to prepare). This social pressure makes it easier to stay focused and avoid distractions.
3. **Start a frustration list.** When something annoys or frustrates you, write it down. This simple practice can significantly reduce the emotional toll of those distractions and help you process them more effectively later.
4. **Turn notes into action:** Each week, schedule time to review your notes or captured thoughts, decide which ones to tackle, and add them to your calendar (as a commitment to yourself - add external validation if needed).

CAREER GROWTH

Effective at Managing Up: How to ensure your manager knows all that you do

Most likely, your manager is not aware of all of your contributions. In a recent [HBR study](#), it was revealed that managers only retain 60% of their teams' efforts. This alarming statistic, particularly relevant now that most companies are in the middle of annual talent reviews, sheds light on the downsides of managers relying solely on intuition, judgment, and experience. Shockingly, an extreme case in this study showed a manager only able to describe a 4% of their team's work. McKinsey has mainly attributed the challenges posed by information overload and task volume as the reason leading managers to overlooking crucial details. Companies believe that returning to the office will resolve these issues, evidence suggests otherwise.

Managers should do something. To bridge this knowledge gap, managers must proactively enhance their understanding through consistent and open communication with their teams. Managers who actively engage in transparent communication and remain accessible are better equipped to comprehend the complexity and details of ongoing projects. A Gallup survey further emphasizes the importance of setting clear expectations and providing regular feedback as essential managerial practices.

The reality is that you cannot leave this up to your manager, you need to "manage up"! This proactive approach ensures that contributions don't go unnoticed. To accomplish this, we should actively communicate project updates, achievements, and challenges with our managers. Managing up is not about ego-boosting; rather, it's a strategic approach to promote communication, collaboration, and overall productivity. Key tactics include regular updates and adapting to the manager's communication style. By adopting these strategies, employees can empower themselves and contribute to a more informed and productive work environment, while ensuring none of your contributions go unnoticed.

How to have an effective communication with your manager? During your [Weekly Review](#), recap every detail of how and where your time was spent. Organize this information into themes for clarity (please don't go to your manager with a laundry list). If your manager is "too busy" for a face-to-face discussion, send the agenda via email. When structuring your 1-to-1, ensure you cover the following key points:

1. **Main Focus Areas:** Align your current week's activities with the overarching goals previously established. Confirm that your priorities remain in line with the organization's objectives.
2. **Progress Towards Deliverables:** Provide an update on how you are tracking towards your upcoming deliverables. This ensures transparency and allows for any necessary adjustments to be made.
3. **Plans and Priorities for Next Week:** Outline your main plans and priorities for the upcoming week, maintaining a forward-looking perspective.
- 4.

5. **Highlight Achievements:** Showcase your main achievements and seek guidance on how to communicate them broadly as organizational successes. Yes, this can feel like patting yourself on the back, but it is sometimes needed.
6. **Challenges and Roadblocks:** Be candid about any challenges or roadblocks you are currently facing and actively seek assistance where needed.
7. **Time Wasters:** Dedicate a portion of the discussion to the percentage of your total week not directly spent on delivering priorities, commonly known as "Time Wasters." This may include activities like unblocking team members, attending status update meetings, or dealing with inefficient systems. If Time Wasters are consuming a significant portion of your bandwidth, propose strategies to reduce them.

This the last point is important to ensure your manager knows what you do. Your manager will acknowledge that you handle various tasks beyond just priorities, a natural aspect of your role that might sometimes be overlooked. This will prevent your manager from overestimating your capacity for upcoming projects, and also it will shed light on the often unnoticed but crucial tasks that contribute to project success or tasks where you need their support to streamline

There is no "right way" for how to structure an effective 1-to-1 meeting with your manager. I gave an example above, but [here](#) are other examples. Just try to find what works for you, but don't miss on acknowledging the "Time Wasters".

An Effective Career Growth Strategy: Succeeding with the PIE (Performance-Image-Exposure) Model

As you probably know by now, I have explored tons of books on personal development. One framework has consistently stood out despite being written close to 30 years, significantly shaping my own career trajectory and constantly coming up when mentoring others—the PIE model (Performance-Image-Exposure) detailed in Harvey Coleman's "[Empowering Yourself: The Organizational Game Revealed](#)." I am sharing the details below and as usual, an action plan for you all to give it a try.

The PIE Model, states that while exceptional Performance is undeniably the bedrock for career advancement, it accounts for only 10% of the factors driving success. Image and Exposure, on the other hand, contribute 30% and 60%, respectively. Image revolves around perception and personal branding, emphasizing effective communication, behavioral awareness, and a robust personal brand beyond mere competence. This extends beyond mere competence, underlining the role of confidence, interpersonal soft skills, and overall demeanor in shaping one's professional image. Exposure, highlights the strategic visibility one must cultivate in the workplace - actively seeking opportunities, networking, engaging in high-profile projects, and strategically positioning oneself within the organizational structure.

Sponsors and Culture Fit. Coleman introduces these two additional concepts that complement the PIE model. Sponsorship involves influential figures advocating for your career advancement, going beyond traditional mentorship by leveraging credibility and connections. Aligning with organizational culture, a concept often overlooked, is emphasized as crucial for success, involving an understanding of unwritten rules, social norms, and unspoken expectations within a company.

Three Steps to leverage the PIE model for career growth

Step 1: Develop a strategy and set goals

- **Performance:** Clearly define your performance goals, align projects with higher-level organizational objectives, and establish verbal alignment with your manager on expectations.
- **Image:** Focus on effective communication, relationship-building, and aligning with your organizational level's communication expectations. Even pay attention to how you dress (although I highly oppose this one, it is a common unconscious bias). Set goals such as attending communication trainings
- **Exposure:** Actively seek opportunities, question if you are involved in high-visibility projects, strategically network, identify potential sponsors, and share regular updates showcasing your achievements. Set goals such as number of people you meet in a month or officially getting one sponsor.

Step 2: Self-Assessment and Feedback

- **Performance:** Seek feedback from your manager.
- **Image:** Request feedback on how others perceive you. Ask things such as: how they perceive you vs. company's values, and what are top three adjectives that describe you (Pick 10 out [these 50](#))
- **Exposure:** Evaluate how many leaders in your organization are aware of your contributions.

Step 3: Close Gaps and Track Progress

- Address gaps identified in Step 2, incorporating a progress tracker in your [Weekly Reviews](#), and setting Quarterly Review milestones.

Pro Tip: [Share your goals](#) with others to create a positive image, gain exposure, and receive feedback for performance improvement.

Implementing these steps ensures a holistic approach to career growth, addressing not only performance goals but also image and exposure objectives. Remember, you can't spell "improvement" without P-I-E.

Effective Communication Norms

Last week, I explored the importance of conducting effective meetings, highlighting that we devote nearly 45% of our workweek to them, with a staggering 69% deemed unnecessary. I emphasized that high-performing organizations tend to have more meetings but highlighted the need for effectiveness.

To enhance the structure of my recommendations, I've refined [the article](#) and this [LinkedIn post](#) by breaking down the strategy for more efficient meetings into three key components: (1) Cover the Basics: such as crafting agendas, limiting attendees, and managing time effectively; (2) Establishing clear communication norms within the team; and (3) Considering a shift in the default meeting structure, for instance, adopting the concept of Office Hours. A lot has been said about the basics, so I want to focus this article on the crucial aspect of establishing clear Team Communication Norms.

Effective Communication Norms

Group norms are the set of informal and formal ground rules that dictate how people interact. They can be explicit, intentionally outlining what is acceptable, or can be implicit, unspoken assumptions that can lead to detrimental practices, like after-hours communication. Crafting norms intentionally ensures a healthy team culture and efficient adaptation to evolving circumstances.

Norms help shape a team's culture. As [this image](#) states: Values are the beliefs of a group. Norms are the rules that shape how the group interacts. Together, they create the culture of a group. The way a team interacts is super important as the success of a team is measured as a collective, and [interactions increase exponentially with larger teams](#), with 3 people having 3 connecting, but 14 people having 91 connection.

The best teams have clear communications norms. These need to be able to address how and when to best communicate, reducing friction, and leading to better team morale, faster problem solving, better decision-making, reduced conflicts, and overall increased productivity. Based on my research and own experience, here are some steps to build your team's communication norms:

Steps to build your communication norms

1. **Assess your team's current communication practices.** Create a survey to identify your team's strengths and areas needing improvement. Consider questions that will help you understand the current status, expectations and gaps. [Here is an example](#) of a survey I created and used to build team norms in the past (edit and make your own).

2. **Define team Communication Norms:** [Here is an example](#) of norms I built based on the survey.
 1. **Cover the basics for meetings:** Define rules that people should follow for good meeting etiquette. See my [five main tips](#).
 2. **Identify all key communications channels and expected response times.** The main insight I have encountered when doing this with teams is that people complain a lot about how unreasonable their team's communications expectations are, but when it is time to state their own expectation when they are the senders, those tend to also fall under the "unreasonable" bucket, such as expecting direct communications to be answered within the hour or emails by end of day (which would be impossible given the volume).
 3. **Evaluate having times without meetings.** "No-meeting Fridays" have become really trendy; however, based on our circadian rhythms, we cannot be fully concentrated for such extended periods of time. Try "no-meeting" time blocks which you can start a couple of days a week and then scale. If your team is in diverse time-zones, a meeting-free day would work great.
 4. **Other example of norms: (1) Clarify when to escalate:** Prevent those disagreeing to waste time trying to convince each other, without either having the approval rights; **(2) Assign time for team development:** whether it is half a day a month, or a full day a quarter, encourage your team to upskill; **(3) Providing feedback:** You can encourage people to use something like the [radical candor](#) approach.
3. **Define what happens when someone misses on your newly created norm.** I have been in teams where we paid a dollar for every minute we were late for a meeting, in another team we had an embarrassing-looking trophy (I'll spare you the details) that whoever came last to the meeting had to display at their desk. Whatever it is, try to connect missing a norm with something, even if it is something funny, so people know that these norms are being taken into consideration.
4. **Document, align, and have them actually sign norms.** Document your norms with simple language. Look for consensus, and once it is aligned with the team (and this might sound a bit cliché) have people actually acknowledge by signing the norms as part of their way to operate is important. Similar to how they would do for a contract.
5. **Create a way to get recurrent feedback and update norms.** Ask for every meeting to end with a satisfaction score 1 to 10 (similar to [level 10 meetings](#)). Also, ask monthly what is the team's overall perception of the norms: are people following them, is there any missing or any that doesn't make sense. Receive feedback and update as needed. Remember norms are living agreements.

Bonus: If you are a member of a leadership team, make the 1-10 satisfaction score for meetings an input metric you track as part of your employee satisfaction goals. This will be a great tangible input metric towards a rather ambiguous out goal of employee work satisfaction

To some of you, the steps above might read as an overkill, and I personally have never been a part of a team who has done all of this well. It is hard for sure, but whatever you apply will be a step forward, so try an incremental approach. Just beware that the biggest reasons I have seen norms fail are: there are too many, nothing really happens when people don't follow them, the leaders don't "walk the talk", and their compliance isn't really being tracked.

Effective at Ikigai: What we were told and what it really is

What Westerners misunderstand about Ikigai. In the Western hemisphere, Ikigai has often been misconstrued as a formulaic path to uncovering one's purpose and fulfillment in life. Many mistakenly associate the concept with a popular [Venn diagram](#) crafted by astrologer Andres Zuzunaga in 2011. Originally intended to show his perspective on purpose, blogger Marc Winn later adapted the diagram, substituting "Ikigai" for "purpose." This diagram suggests that "Ikigai" involves finding the intersection of what one loves, what the world needs, what one excels at, and what one can be paid for. However, this Western interpretation is radically different to with the authentic Japanese understanding of Ikigai (read the full story [here](#)).

The true essence of Ikigai for the Japanese. Contrary to the Venn diagram's depiction, Ikigai centers around a profound sense of purpose and joy in life, stemming from multiple small pleasures that enrich our daily existence, rather than a single passion or triumph in a specific area. Rooted in Japanese culture since the Heian period (794-1185 AD), Ikigai revolves around finding pleasure from our everyday rituals, fostering connections with others, and savoring life's simple joys, while prioritizing engagements that imbue life with meaning. It embodies living authentically and finding delight in the present moment, or as the Ikigai book puts it: "the happiness of always being busy, yet never rushed."

Simplifying Ikigai. While the Venn diagram may be "Instagrammable," it sets an exceptionally high bar for all of us. Is it realistic to expect that we can discover something we love, excel at, aligns with societal needs, AND is financially retributed? Instead, let's embrace Ikigai as a guiding philosophy that encourages us to find joy in life's small moments, through nurturing relationships or connecting with nature. In aggregate, we can indeed pursue things that we love, what we excel at, what the world needs, and earn compensation in the process, though these may span multiple facets of our lives rather than being confined to all to our profession.

Distinguishing between job and vocation. Reflecting on this concept, I recall [Sean Johnson's framework](#), which defines a job as what one is paid for, and a vocation as what brings the greatest joy. This subtly differs from the Ikigai Venn diagram's interpretation of vocation (what the world needs and you can get paid to do). Johnson states that transforming a vocation into a job may diminish its intrinsic joy (consider the contrast between cooking for loved ones versus managing a restaurant). This concept echoes sentiments from "[The Good Enough Job](#)" that cautions us to "[beware of dream jobs](#)," as many passion-driven professions (think teacher, zoo keeper, librarian, etc.) often are overworked and underpaid. In times of doubt, let's remember that even [Nikola Jokic](#) acknowledges that playing in the NBA is his job, not his vocation.

How can you leverage this newly acquired knowledge?

1. **Take the Ikigai 9 survey:** A short 9-question questionnaire to determine your level of Ikigai, developed by Japanese scholars.
2. **Amplify joy in your life:** During your [Weekly Review](#), strategize how to allocate more time to these joy-inducing activities, or explore ways to enhance your engagement with them.
3. **(If you're unsure) Discover what brings you joy:** Explore avenues such as seeking guidance from a coach or maintaining a journal to unveil recurring sources of happiness.
4. **Establish boundaries:** If your sources of joy differ from your profession, set clear boundaries. Research from the Mayo Clinic suggests that dedicating a significant portion of time to activities you love can mitigate burnout; however, anything beyond 20% has a marginal impact.

Anecdotally, I noticed how much I enjoyed developing others and set a small portion of my week to work on it, topping at around 20% when I was doing in-person trainings. I managed to do this by following the steps in [this article I wrote a few months ago](#). Hope it helps.

Effective Decision-making at Work

What's the theory behind?

Plan to overcome your biases. You probably know by now that our decision-making process is filled with biases. I have previously mentioned tons of potential biases, but below, I want to highlight three important concepts to consider when at work:

Groupthink happens when people try to avoid conflict. People decide to prioritize consensus or go with the least disruptive option. At work, this usually leads the majority to agree with the person(s) with the most tenure or level. Usually resulting in a biased outcome as some voices are virtually being silenced.

"The paradox of Choice" refers to how providing more choices actually leads to worse decisions. In his [famous book](#), Barry Schwartz shows how too many choices can lead to decision paralysis, anxiety, and general dissatisfaction. He shows that limiting available options can actually enhance well-being, by reducing the anxiety caused by having "excessive choices". At work, simplifying choices is actually an art of balance: if you present leadership few choices they might think you have just scratched the surface of the problem at hand; if you present them with a lot of choices, then you haven't put your own thinking into the problem. I know, hard, right?

Two way door and one way door decisions. Jeff Bezos' [well renowned concept](#) talks about differentiating between irreversible (one-way door) and reversible (two-way door) decisions. At Amazon, people are constantly being incentivized to turn one-way into two-way doors as a way to be able to move fast without having to deal with the large implications of a potential failure. Another popular analogy I read comes from [James Clear's](#) definition of how decisions are either hats, haircuts, or tattoos (each with different costs for mistakes).

How to make effective decisions at work?

1. **Clearly outline the objective and define potential alternatives**
 1. **Narrow your choices down to approx. 3:** If you don't want to risk leadership viewing you as not having dove deep enough, then you can add more alternatives in the appendix.
 2. **Do a Pre-mortem:** Give pros/cons (or benefit/costs) for each option. Clearly outline what is the worst thing that can happen.
2. **Get the right people on board before getting to the approver.** I know, it will take time to go to the different groups individually, but for important decisions it is the best way gather unbiased feedback, and avoid groupthink.
3. **Turn your decision into a two-way door.** Think about how you can reduce the costs/risks involved with your proposed decision. For instance, you can turn your decision-making process into a series of experiments. You can then push the date by which you will make the final decision, and actually just have to decide what you are trying out until that time (another famous Bezos question is: "When is the latest we can make this decision?")
4. **Set clear success criteria to move forward.** Do this ahead of time, before you get biased or care too much about a particular alternative.
5. **Bonus: You can use an existing decision-making framework.** There are two I like:
 1. **SPADE:** Setting, People, Alternatives, Decide, and Explain. [Here](#) is a real life example.
 2. **DECIDE:** Define the problem by taking a step backwards first, Establish the criteria that will determine success, Consider Alternatives, Identify the best alternative, Develop and implement a plan of action with deadlines, Evaluate the solution)

My personal thoughts - Sharing my personal two cents:

1. It has happened to me multiple times that when deciding amongst options, we end up creating a Frankenstein version of all the options and going with that. It has happened so frequently, now I create this merged version proactively.
2. Don't forget to plan for and embrace uncertainty (the famous "[unknown-unknowns](#)"). Time and time again I have been in teams that plan to do things nobody has done before, and don't account for the fact that there will be unforeseen obstacles. Add some buffer to your plan.

Effective at Quitting while you are ahead: Is the juice worth the squeeze?

I spent last weekend in Vegas with friends, where I watched the Champions League final and was amazed by Toni Kroos' decision to retire at the top of his career. He could literally continue more years and make more money in lesser competitive teams, but he is not. Quitting while ahead is an important yet overlooked skill.

[Side note: I [previously mentioned](#) how Disney Parks is an entire industry built for our "remembering selves," well, Vegas is the opposite, built for our "experiencing selves." it is good to balance both.]

The Theory

In business and life, knowing when to quit is key. Success is usually associated with perseverance, yet there comes a point when continuing can lead to diminishing returns or failure. Recognizing the right time to step away from a project, job, or career can ensure we preserve our legacies, prevent burnout, and even create new and better opportunities. People like Toni Kroos, Jacinda Ardern, and Jerry Seinfeld exemplify mastering the art of quitting at their peaks while potentially "leaving some things behind".

We need to constantly assess if "[the juice is worth the squeeze](#)". Seth Godin's "[The Dip](#)" emphasizes that temporary setbacks can be overcome with persistence, but it's essential to distinguish "dips" from "dead ends". To do so, it is important to assess if the current goals (the juice) are worth pursuing given the required resources (the squeeze). If the effort aligns with meaningful goals, persistence is justified. Recognizing a dead end early saves valuable resources for other opportunities.

We are biased towards thinking we just need to "push through." [Annie Duke's "Quit"](#) highlights biases that lead to irrational persistence: forgetting we could be placing our efforts into other alternatives (opportunity costs), overestimating past investments (the sunk cost fallacy), and a natural emotional attachment to projects. Additionally, adopting a small bet mentality to test alternatives can be game-changing, allowing for experimentation without having to make a huge jump. It is also important to place a bet on existing team members as part of a succession plan that ensures continuity for the team and a strong legacy for yourself.

My personal thoughts

I have been always conflicted by the [theories](#) recommending us to have grit (push through obstacles) and actually quit when we don't deem them worth it. In 2018, I faced a rough patch at work and reach out to five mentors for advice on what to do, expecting a pep talk about perseverance. Surprisingly all five recommended quitting and finding another job. The main reason behind this unanimous recommendation

was that I was going to need to put a lot of effort into something that wasn't aligned to my long-term career goal. This aligned with the theory of knowing when to quit, and looking back, it was actually a good decision.

How to put this into practice

1. **Regularly evaluate your progress and satisfaction with current projects.** Identify if challenges are temporary setbacks (dips) or persistent issues (dead ends). There's many ways to do this, journaling is one of the most popular ones.
2. **Reassess goals and milestones.** We sometimes divert from our original goals and don't even notice it. We need to track progress recurrently and see if we need to make adjustments.
3. **Analyze Costs and Benefits (Is the juice worth the squeeze?).** Compare the resources (time, money, energy) invested to the returns received. Determine if the effort to overcome current challenges is justified by potential benefits, and if the benefits are still aligned with your goals. If not, consider redirecting efforts.
4. **Aim to reduce biases by seeking an unbiased perspective.** This person will help you determine opportunity costs, recognize sunk costs, and detach from your emotions.
5. **Develop a Quitting Strategy.** Plan potential exits and experiment with small bets to test new opportunities. Include a succession plan for a smooth transition and a good legacy.

Realistically, this is challenging, but it happens frequently. The key is not to "push through" no matter what but to constantly evaluate if it's worth doing so. We all need to be evaluating our goals and challenges constantly, just as Toni Kroos did, recognizing that quitting is sometimes the wisest choice.

Effective Customer Obsession: This Newsletter Turns 1 Year Old

As I celebrated my birthday last week ([here are 18 reflections](#)), I realized it's also the one-year anniversary of this newsletter. Writing publicly has been a new and sometimes [uncomfortable journey](#), so I'm deeply grateful for your support.

Over the past year, I've grown, learned, and connected with many of you. Now, as I see encouraging metrics (see PS section below for full details) and take this hobby more seriously, I'm committed to following a principle that I've been taught throughout my career: **making my efforts truly customer-obsessed**. My goal is to better understand your needs and make this newsletter (and all future projects) more valuable for you.

The Theory: Why Customer Obsession Matters

Customer obsession goes beyond being a buzzword; it's a philosophy that can transform both businesses and personal relationships. The idea is simple - It's about deeply understanding your customers' pain points and "[working backwards](#)" to find solutions. The execution is more of an art than a science.

Cultivating [1,000 True Fans](#) means focusing on a loyal, smaller base rather than the masses. This principle isn't just for big brands and it doesn't need to cover a thousand people - it's equally powerful on a personal level, with a smaller group of stakeholders. For instance, at work, instead of trying to please everyone, ask yourself: who are your true fans, and are you serving them well?

Feedback is a gift. The best way to understand your customers (and their pain points) is by proactively seeking their input. Don't wait for an annual talent review or for issues to arise - ask your customers, clients, peers, and stakeholders for feedback regularly. A couple of tips: let people know in advance that you'll be asking for feedback, and focus on the process or project rather than making it personal. This approach makes feedback easier to give and more actionable.

My Personal Thoughts: Who Are Your True Fans?

In our professional lives, "customers" aren't just the people who buy our products - they're also our stakeholders, managers, and direct reports. These are the people whose support and trust we need to succeed. Are they your true fans? Are you customer-obsessed in your approach to these relationships? Cultivating this mindset can transform your work environment, encouraging mutual respect and collaboration.

Customer Obsession is now my priority. I want to get to know you better before focusing on scaling this newsletter and my upcoming projects. In addition to [completing this survey](#) (they say third time's a charm), next week, I'll reach out to those who have been especially supportive (I'm calling it my "Inner Circle"), to see how I can add more value for their support, like choosing topics or joining group coaching/Q&A calls. If you complete the survey, you'll automatically join this Inner Circle.

How to Put This Into Practice: Embracing Customer Obsession in Your Work

1. **Identify Your "Customers":** Both internal and external. Create a list with the names of your main stakeholders.
2. **Understand Their Pain Points:** For example, do you know what keeps your manager up at night?
3. **Cultivate Your True Fans:** Focus on those who can have the most impact - your manager, direct reports, skip-levels, and those on your promotion panel.
4. **Seek Feedback Continuously:** Don't wait for formal reviews. Take this opportunity to seek feedback and use it to improve. Remember: give a heads-up when you'll be asking, and start by seeking feedback on the project, not yourself.
5. **Keep Track of Your List of Customers:** In addition to their names, create a list that includes: when you last met them, the feedback they gave, and your plan to follow up by showing how you addressed their feedback.

Effective at Seeking Mentorship: Focus on being a great mentee

Thank you to everyone who filled out [this form](#)! It's giving me great insight into who's reading this newsletter. For example, nearly 20% of you are working parents. I've always said the true test of what I've learned about effectiveness came when I had kids. Juggling two kids and two corporate jobs, while living away from family, has been the hardest thing I've ever done - now imagine what it's been like for my wife dealing with all that plus me (haha). If you haven't already, take a moment to fill out this [short 10-question form](#) to request topics tailored to you.

Today, I want to talk about mentorship. It's always been a bit tricky for me - I've studied it and tried to master it, but while I never became a rockstar mentor or mentee, I wasn't bad at it either. Below, I'll share some theory, personal insights, and (as always) an actionable plan.

The Theory

Mentorship has a proven impact on business success. Employees with mentors experience higher career growth, and companies with mentoring programs see better retention, morale, and performance. [98% of Fortune 500 companies](#) have mentorship programs, and those with mentors are five times more likely to advance within the organization, over other [significant benefits](#).

Finding a mentor can be tough, but rapport makes a big difference. Despite the advantages, [56% of American workers](#) still don't have a mentor. Why? Time constraints and awkwardness often stand in the way. Many people benefit from finding mentors with similar backgrounds or experiences, making it easier to build trust. [Employee Resource Groups \(ERGs\)](#) are great for this, offering a structured way to connect with people who share similar demographics or interests. Mentors from ERGs can help break down the initial awkwardness and foster more genuine relationships.

My personal thoughts

Never start by asking "Will you be my mentor?" It's like Simon Sinek says: "Would you go up to a stranger and ask them to be friends?" I believe many mentorship issues come from unclear incentives. While it's clear what the mentee gets, what's in it for the mentor? Make it easy for them by asking for a few minutes of their time and keeping it light. You can then seek out different people for different topics and add them to your "mentor rolodex" (yes, I just revealed my age with that reference).

Make the experience rewarding for your mentor. As someone who mentors others, I can tell you, I love helping people, but most of the time, I don't hear back about how they actually used my advice. Or worse, they ask questions they could've googled. So, two tips: (1) Do your homework before the meeting (search in the company wiki, google, AI, etc.); and (2) Always update your mentor on what you did with their advice, even if you didn't use it, but just acknowledging you took it into consideration.

Maybe you don't need a mentor at all. Many people look to more senior people as mentors, but I see these people more as sponsors. I'm not 100% vulnerable with them, and I come prepared (i.e. they could be a manager in the future). When I'm really stuck, I usually seek peer mentorship - someone close to my level who's recently faced similar challenges. IMO, these are often the most helpful relationships.

In 2021, I was too busy to mentor, managing a global team and multiple projects. After some reflection, I realized I missed mentoring and said "yes" to everyone who asked - regardless of level or time zone. That year, I agreed to meet with around 50 people. The most surprising part? About a third never scheduled or canceled last minute. At first, I was frustrated, but then I realized these were people struggling with workload management - so much that they couldn't even attend the meeting (oh, the irony). In the end, a good mentor-mentee relationship should be led by the mentee, so I came up with the following five recommendations.

Actionable next steps

1. **Seek someone for whom it's also a win:** Look for mentors who share similar experiences (or demographics) or want (need) to develop their mentoring skills. ERGs are a great resource for this.
2. **Do your homework:** Make sure you've researched your questions or tried solving them on your own before asking for someone's time (Google, AI, company resources). If you're still in doubt, at least come with the options you've researched.
3. **Clarify your goals for one meeting:** Be specific about what you need and minimize the time commitment for the mentor. Keep it light, try to avoid using the word "mentorship."
4. **Show that their time was well spent:** Always follow up with a recap of how you applied their advice.
5. **Leverage multiple mentors:** Different perspectives are crucial, especially early in your career. Remember sometimes the best mentorship comes from peers.

I hope you find your Mr. Miyagi! Bonus tip for those reading this far: Ask your manager who their best direct report has been and why - then seek that person for mentorship on that specific skill. Boom!

The Effective 40-hour workweek: Making a Century-Old Model Work for You

On September 25th, the 40-hour workweek turns 98. I wrote about it last year and felt it was time to revisit the topic. It's wild that, despite all the progress we've made as a society, we still hold onto this outdated model. In 1926, streets were full of horses - now, we debate AI replacing jobs, yet most of us still work 9-to-5. [Side note: I think I've improved as a writer, so feel free to check my [previous article](#) and let me know if you agree.]

I thought the pandemic would finally end this centennial model. Remote work, more flexibility - it seemed like we were heading in the right direction. Yet, many companies, [Amazon](#) being the latest, are reverting to pre-pandemic norms. Did we learn nothing from the past 4.5 years?

Will this ever change? Will AI reduce our work hours? No one knows for sure, but I have some thoughts and a proposal. Keep reading if you're curious.

The Theory

Henry Ford introduced the 40-hour workweek in 1926, a game-changing decision at the time. Prior to this, it was common for workers to clock-in 60 to 80 hours a week, especially in factories. Ford saw that exhausted workers were less productive and believed reducing hours would improve efficiency and even turn workers into better consumers of the cars they built (capitalism at its finest!). This move reshaped labor standards around the world.

Experts once predicted working hours would keep shrinking. In 1930, economist John Maynard Keynes [famously predicted](#) a 15-hour workweek by 2030, mainly due to technology. But despite huge advances, we're still working around 40 hours. Where did the promised extra leisure time go?

Different models have been tested but none feels like a "slam dunk." Countries like Iceland, New Zealand, and Spain have conducted successful experiments with four-day workweeks. In contrast, Greece is reportedly considering adopting a six-day workweek, mainly due to economic reasons. Overall, the results are inconclusive, and even when test results look promising, most remain hesitant to scale.

Parkinson's Law offers a possible explanation: "work expands to fill the time available." This means that, no matter how much time we have (40 or 20 hours), we tend to fill it with tasks. This is a key productivity concept that could help us rethink how we approach our workweek [Side note: This might also explain why in my last three moves I've ended up using exactly the same number of boxes I had available.]

My personal Thoughts

At the [2024 Work Design Conference](#), the future of work was highlighted as being focused on flexibility and purpose. For some, well-being might mean working zero hours one week; for others, it could mean 80 hours of meaningful work. Research supports that aligning well-being (psychological safety) with job demands boosts both productivity and fulfillment. However, it won't be a one-size-fits-all solution, making it difficult to implement specially for larger companies.

My take? The 40-hour workweek isn't disappearing soon, especially for big companies rooted in traditional models. However, I do believe smaller, flexible companies will experiment with new approaches, offering it as a perk that goes beyond free lunches and chair massages. Flexibility is becoming the ultimate office perk - 51% of workers would switch jobs for it, [according to Gallup](#). This gives companies with flexible options a big advantage in attracting talent.

My recommendation: Don't wait for policy changes. Apply Parkinson's Law.

Challenge yourself to finish your work in fewer hours and free up time for more impactful projects. I used this approach at Amazon, setting aside Friday afternoons for side projects. That focus helped me launch trainings and a community that were never part of my full-time job. You don't need permission to make more effective use of your time.

How to put this into practice?

1. **Rank Your Key Deliverables:** Focus on what truly moves the needle and question what falls to the bottom.
2. **Set a Time Constraint:** Complete tasks in 90% of the time or limit yourself to 90% of the tasks. Tip: Imagine your computer shuts off at a set time.
3. **Create a Weekly Focus Block:** Start with 2 hours on Friday afternoons for important but non-urgent tasks. Focus on things you consider important but never seem to have time for, like: skill development, networking, or writing an innovation proposal.
4. **Gradually Expand:** Increase this block to four hours, creating a half-day each week for neglected priorities.
5. **Important: Don't skip key deliverables.** Cover new projects but never at the expense of not delivering a core task. Need help cutting 3 hours from your calendar? I have a system. Reply to this email - happy to assist

In the end, the 40-hour workweek may not vanish soon, but you can still make it work for you.

The Effective Rizz: Charisma in the Workplace

Last week, my eldest son turned 7, and suddenly, I went from being 'papá' to "[bruh](#)." I also learned that apparently, I "have no rizz." If you're as lost as I was, "rizz" (short for charisma) was named "[Word of the Year](#)" in 2023. New generations use "rizz" to describe someone's ability to effortlessly charm, connect, and influence others through charisma and social skills.

So, what's the connection with being effective? The Wall Street Journal suggests "rizz" might be the [secret to getting ahead at work](#). In the corporate world, it enhances communication, builds relationships, and fosters trust (key for leadership, collaboration, and growth). Outside of work, it helps build strong friendships and connections.

So, do you want to be a Rizzler? The Rizzard of Oz? Rizzy McGuire? This too is a skill you can learn. Read on for practical tips.

The Theory

How to Win Friends and Influence People: Dale Carnegie's [famous book](#) is a blueprint for mastering "rizz." The key principles (showing genuine interest in others, smiling, being positive, avoiding criticism, and using people's names) are all timeless tips that align perfectly with modern "rizz." Carnegie's advice to make others feel important is central to charisma; it's about making others feel valued, which is just as relevant in today's workplaces.

"Rizz" embodies [Bourdieu's Theory of Capital](#). In professional settings, influence often depends more on the networks and social connections you build than on technical skills alone. When you invest in authentic, meaningful relationships and understand the cultural norms of your environment, you are accumulating valuable **social and cultural capital**. This capital opens doors for collaborations, partnerships, and mentorships. It's about building genuine, mutually beneficial connections that enhance your influence and reputation.

EQ and "Rizz." High Emotional Intelligence (EQ) means being aware of your own emotions and those of others, allowing you to navigate conversations with empathy and understanding. EQ elements like active listening, empathy, and adaptability are key to building charisma. It's about reading the room and adjusting your energy accordingly - knowing when to be upbeat and when to take a more thoughtful, calm approach. The better you can read and respond to these dynamics, the more effectively you can connect with others.

My personal thoughts (keep at 200 words)

Corporate "Rizz" Defined: Based on the [WSJ article](#), corporate "rizz" is the ability to blend confidence with authenticity. It's not about being the loudest voice but about actively listening, showing interest, and making others feel comfortable and valued. Embrace your quirks instead of chasing perfection; people trust relatability over polish. People trust those who are relatable, not those who seem perfect.

What I Find Most Relevant: In remote and hybrid environments, meaningful connections are still possible. Remembering small details, like someone's pet's name, makes your virtual presence impactful. I found [Charisma on Command](#) on YouTube to be a practical resource for this. It offers tips on active listening, handling teasing, and introducing yourself with confidence, using examples from charismatic figures like Tom Holland, Chris Evans, Jack Harlow, and Keanu Reeves. It also highlights Robert Downey Jr.'s "quick wit" and Ryan Reynolds's humor, showing how these techniques elevate virtual interactions.

How to put this into practice

1. **Develop Active Listening:** Don't just hear - engage. Nod, ask follow-up questions, and show genuine care for others' perspective.
2. **Adapt to Situations:** Just like situational leadership, understand the vibes of a meeting or conversation and adjust your approach to match the energy - whether it's energetic brainstorming or thoughtful problem-solving.
3. **Study Body Language:** Align your verbal and non-verbal cues: maintain eye contact, mirror gestures, and adopt attentive postures. (Pro Tip: Showing your palms when speaking conveys openness and honesty).
4. **Show Appreciation:** Set a weekly reminder to send a thank-you note recognizing a colleague's efforts.

Ultimately, rizz is about making others feel seen and valued.

Effective Psychological Safety: Celebrating Halloween Reflects Team Success

Yesterday was Halloween, and if you follow me on LinkedIn, you might have seen my post about [psychological safety and Halloween costumes](#). So, what does Halloween have to do with psychological safety? Simple - it takes safety to dress up as your favorite character in front of your team. Keep reading to understand why psychological safety is crucial to building high-performing teams.

The Theory

Psychological safety is the foundation of successful teams. [Harvard's Amy Edmondson](#) defines it as an environment where individuals feel comfortable taking interpersonal risks without fear of judgment. She describes psychologically safe spaces as those where team members can speak up, admit mistakes, and ask questions openly. These are essential to drive both personal and team growth. When psychological safety is in place, teams perform better, innovate more, and build resilience against setbacks.

There are [four levels of Psychological Safety](#). (1) Included: where people feel they belong; (2) Learning: where they feel safe to ask questions; (3) Contributing: where they feel confident they can add value and make a difference; and (4) Challenging: where they feel comfortable speaking out, questioning the status quo. Climbing up these levels helps teams progress from basic trust to open innovation. It's only by reaching these levels that a team unlocks its true collaborative potential.

Google studied what makes a team successful and found one key attribute. You probably guessed by now. [Google's Project Aristotle](#) identified psychological safety as the top predictor of team success. Teams that feel safe to experiment and even fail tend to communicate better, adapt faster, and innovate more. In other words, when people feel safe, everyone benefits.

My Own Thoughts

Psychological safety is often confused with trust, but it goes beyond that. In my opinion, trust is about confidence between individuals; psychological safety is the broader team culture, where everyone feels they can be authentic without fear, and contributions are valued.

Some of the best teams I've worked with celebrated Halloween together, often with costume contests. These traditions made us feel safe enough to put ourselves out there and build stronger bonds. [Side note: I usually dress up as a monster or superhero - I'm 6'5" (195 cm) tall, so that helps! This year, I was [Steve Hyuga](#); if you know him, we're now officially friends].

How to Put This Into Practice

Building psychological safety requires effort from both managers and employees. When both roles contribute, the team creates a safe space where everyone can voice ideas, share feedback, and learn from each other without fear. Here's how each can play their part:

1. **Lead with Vulnerability**
 - **Manager:** Share your own mistakes openly, showing that it's okay not to have all the answers.
 - **Employee:** Be honest about needing help or when you've made an error. This builds trust and signals openness.
2. **Encourage Open Dialogue**
 - **Manager:** Create regular spaces (like team meetings) where all ideas and questions are welcome. Make it clear that all input is valued.
 - **Employee:** Actively participate and contribute your perspectives. Support colleagues when they share theirs to reinforce open communication.
3. **Promote Growth from Mistakes:**
 - **Manager:** Frame mistakes as opportunities to learn, using team debriefs to reflect and grow rather than assigning blame.
 - **Employee:** Own your mistakes and share what you've learned. Embrace feedback as part of personal and team growth.
4. **Respect and Value All Voices:**
 - **Manager:** Use inclusive methods like round-robins or direct invitations to ensure everyone has a chance to speak.
 - **Employee:** Respect and listen to each colleague's input, encouraging quieter team members to share their ideas.
5. **Celebrate Wins and Milestones Together:**
 - **Manager:** Lead team celebrations for achievements (big or small) and recognize individual contributions.
 - **Employee:** Participate in celebrations, acknowledging both your accomplishments and those of your teammates.

If your team didn't celebrate Halloween, it's not too late - propose a Friendsgiving, or a strong end-of-year celebration. There's always time.

Effective Email Etiquette

Asynchronous communication occupies about 77% of our work time. Though there's no official source, [experts](#) estimate we exchange around 120-130 emails daily. Consulting [ChatGPT](#), it estimates we receive 121 emails*, send 40, and engage in a dozen direct communications daily. Combined, that's roughly 185 asynchronous interactions. Assuming each takes two minutes, we spend about 6.2 hours (or 77% of our work time) daily on such communication, explaining why we sometimes feel we cannot get work done during working hours.

Consider the types of communication you dislike receiving. Firstly, there are lengthy, unstructured emails, often involving multiple recipients and lacking clear asks or next steps. Secondly, there are requests over Slack or Teams messages that interrupt your tasks, but require so much of your time that you are left unsure whether to prioritize them or request an email instead. In both cases, a usual practice is to start reading, close, and mark as unread. Meaning that we are not only receiving 185 pieces of communication, but also we are voluntarily reading some of them more than once (ouch!).

Your email is competing for the attention of people who are biased to cover the easy first. The majority of people [Cherry-Pick](#) while reading their emails. This phenomenon, driven by our inclination to tackle simple tasks first (from our [Homer Simpson-selves](#)), leads us to feel more accomplished after clearing numerous easy emails than addressing a few challenging ones.

Call to action: 7 tips for effective asynchronous communication, gathered from over a decade of crowdsourcing:

1. **Craft clear subject lines to attract attention:** Make them cherry-pick your email, using brackets or separators. For example: "(Approval needed by EOD) Financial Estimates" or "2min read | Approved Financial Estimates".
2. **Target your email carefully:** Minimize "reply all" usage. Specify any changes in the recipient list (added or removed) at the beginning of the email to keep transparency.
3. **Structure your email concisely:** (1) Start with the main point and ask; (2) Follow with context if necessary (if lengthy, this can be an attachment); (3) Politely offer further clarification if needed; (4) End with a sign-off that suits your style. According to [Mashable](#), the top three are: "All the best", "Thanks", and just your initials (baller move).
4. **Acknowledge receipt:** For time-consuming emails, indicate when you'll respond, preventing uncertainty for the sender.
5. **Be a kind forwarder:** Provide a brief summary of why they're relevant to the recipient rather than just adding them with an "FYI".
6. **(My favorite) Utilize the delayed send feature to retract emails in case of errors:** Instructions are available for [Outlook](#) and [Gmail](#).

7. **Reserve direct messaging (e.g., Slack, Teams) for brief exchanges or urgent matters.** For tasks requiring more than two minutes, use email. Urgent emails should be labeled appropriately and you can then follow up with a direct message. Why 2 minutes? Because productivity guru [David Allen](#) determined so over 20 years ago.

Whether asynchronous communication takes 77% of your work time or a bit less, mastering it remains vital in corporate settings.



GOAL SETTING

Effective at Starting Fresh: Why cleaning up has a positive effect on your productivity

New year, new you. There is actually a psychological phenomenon called the "Fresh Start Effect" that makes us more productive at the beginning of a new time milestone, with increased motivation and renewed energy. This concept implies that the start of a new week, month, year, or even a personal milestone (birthday), can trigger a psychological reset, encouraging people to adopt healthier habits and set new objectives.

When a simple date change is not enough. Let's face it; we sometimes take several weeks to even write down the [date correctly](#) at the beginning of a new year. So, is it realistic to believe that we are now a refreshed version of ourselves compared to what we were last week? Most examples of the "Fresh Start Effect" focus on time milestones; however, research shows that [one of the best times to acquire new habits](#) is when moving to a new house. The act of moving serves as a catalyst for positive change, prompting people to reassess and restructure their routines. Given that it is rare to move so often, there is another thing that people usually do to feel this sense of having a fresh start: cleaning up.

Does it "spark joy"? When I started working in retail, I was surprised to find out that, alongside the well-known categories with sales peaks in January (Fitness Gear, Winter equipment), Americans also see the start of the new year as a time to buy Garage Storage ([see Google Trend](#)). This makes sense. Cleaning up one's room, closet, or desk serves as a catalyst for the "Fresh Start Effect," signaling our brains to take a break from past habits and promoting a clean slate mentally. Organizing and de-cluttering personal spaces have [multiple benefits](#), mainly: enhancing focus, reducing stress, and even increasing creativity. A study by Princeton University showed that visual clutter competes for our attention, leading to decreased performance and increased stress. The American Psychological Association highlights how a clean desk creates a more calming and conducive work environment.

Three things you can do to feel like today is a fresh start?

1. **Clean your closet.** Set aside all the clothes that you haven't worn in a few months. If you don't want to give them away just yet, then remove them from your sight and give them away in three months if you didn't end up using them. Schedule to do this twice a year.

2. **Clean up your desk.** Process all loose papers and notes into a list of things to do and digitize everything you can (you can take pictures). Throw out everything else. If a piece of paper can be important, then store it in a box but far from your sight to avoid it competing for your attention. Schedule this during your [Weekly Review](#).
3. **Create a [#Closing Shift](#) nightly routine.** This is a TikTok trend that Americans who work in the food and retail industries started implementing at their homes, and it makes total sense to feel like every morning is a fresh start.

Effective Personal Quarterly Review: How to do one and why

When you log back in to work on Monday it will already be the second quarter of the year. Yes, time flies! Some of you may already have meticulously planned annual goals, while others might feel a bit overwhelmed by the idea of annual goals and may not have any set up yet. Regardless of where you stand, this post aims to prompt a moment of reflection on your Q1 achievements and how you plan to navigate the rest of the year. This serves as a gentle reminder to revisit the concepts discussed in previous posts regarding [annual retrospectives](#) and [planning your year](#), should you wish to refresh your memory.

Consider the analogy of [the 1-in-60 rule](#) from aviation: Even a slight one-degree error can result in being off course by a significant margin over a long journey (one mile miss for every 60 miles). Picture embarking on a flight from LAX to New York City, only to realize too late that a small 5% error has diverted you to Philadelphia instead. In much the same way, as we navigate our goals for the year, detecting and correcting errors early on can save us from shifting drastically off course later down the line. It emphasizes the importance of being vigilant and proactive in our approach to goal setting and adjustment.

How to conduct an Effective Personal Quarterly Review

Step 1: Reflect. As mentioned in [this article](#), begin by dedicating time for reflection, a crucial step in effective planning. In just 12 minutes, you can kickstart this process:

1. Open your Calendar, Photo app, and Excel, and create a table with columns labeled "Weeks" (13 rows), "High," and "Low."
2. Conduct a one-minute audit per week of your calendar and photos. Document positives and negatives.
3. Celebrate positives and identify common themes.
4. Reflect on negatives, analyze common themes (anything to avoid or get better at?), and extract key learnings.
5. Continuously improve by strategizing how to amplify positives, mitigate negatives, and set realistic goals for the future.

Step 2: Evaluate yourself. If you've set annual goals, perform a Traffic Light ([or RAG](#)) status report for each [See *my personal example below*]:

- Green: On track to achieve the goal. Consider stretching it further if all goals are green.
- Amber: Uncertain; adjustments may be needed.
- Red: Off track; reconsider the goal or your approach.

Step 3: Adjust for Next Quarter. For goals in the amber or red zone, or for those without set annual goals, consider these options:

- **Adjust expectations:** Account for the "[Planning Fallacy](#)" by recalibrating your goals.
- **Remove goals:** Don't feel ashamed. Be realistic about what's achievable.
- **Review systems:** Ensure your systems effectively translate goals into daily actions. A [Weekly Review](#) is highly recommended.

- **You still don't have goals?** Start by creating one right now (you can see my personal examples below for inspiration). It doesn't need to be anything too fancy, just go get started with something small!

Bonus Step: Involve others. Extend this exercise to partners - engage your team at work and your spouse or significant other at home. Inclusion fosters appreciation for shared goals and incentivizes others to help with your progress.

Think of this review as a quick pit stop before continuing on your journey.

Effective Mid-Year Review: Time for Your Half-Time Break

I've been thinking about how to share a familiar message—"there's immense benefit in doing a personal review every quarter"—without repeating myself from [three months ago](#). Ultimately, I decided to keep the "How to Put This Into Practice" section exactly the same for two key reasons: First, only half of you actually open each email (plus, subscribers have nearly doubled - thanks!). Second, quarterly reviews are a genuine part of my routine, and I want to keep it real for you to try.

Many content creators prioritize quantity (sharing various frameworks), but I often wonder how many of those they actually practice themselves. I believe my edge is that I strive to remain relatable by sharing strategies that have genuinely worked for me and others in similar positions. My goal is that after spending 2-3 minutes reading the text below, you'll think, "If he can do it, so can I."

The Theory

When you log back in to work on Monday it will already be the third quarter of the year. Yes, time flies! Some of you may have meticulously planned annual goals, so it is important to reflect on our progress thus far. If you don't have any goals, this is also the right time to set some up for the second half of the year. This serves as a gentle reminder to revisit the concepts discussed in previous posts regarding [annual retrospectives](#) and [planning your year](#), should you wish to refresh your memory.

If you feel like you're falling behind on your goals, develop a Plan B or C instead of sticking to the original plan. Sahil Bloom's [ABC Goal System](#), inspired by marathon training advice, emphasizes the benefit of having multiple goals to ensure progress even when things don't go perfectly. By creating achievable backup plans, you can maintain momentum and avoid discouragement from a total lack of progress. Adapt, reassess, and keep moving forward. Even small gains still compound.

My personal thoughts

Try not to get discouraged. As you'll see in the P.S. section, my goals range from easily attainable to very ambitious, with some marked in green and others in red. I try to keep my themes consistent year after year, aiming to make progress in all areas. Progress can be slow, but I always strive to move forward. It's okay to change or drop a goal if needed. Stay flexible to avoid discouragement. Remember, a year is just a manmade construct - nothing stops you from setting goals with different time horizons.

How to Put This Into Practice

Step 1: Reflect. As mentioned in [this article](#), begin by dedicating time for reflection, a crucial step in effective planning. In just 12 minutes, you can kickstart this process:

1. Open your Calendar, Photo app, and Excel, and create a table with columns labeled "Weeks" (13 rows), "High," and "Low."
2. Conduct a one-minute audit per week of your calendar and photos. Document positives and negatives.
3. Celebrate positives and identify common themes.
4. Reflect on negatives, analyze common themes (anything to avoid or get better at?), and extract key learnings.
5. Continuously improve by strategizing how to amplify positives, mitigate negatives, and set realistic goals for the future.

Step 2: Evaluate yourself. If you've set annual goals, perform a Traffic Light ([or RAG](#)) status report for each [See my personal example below]:

- Green: On track to achieve the goal. Consider stretching it further if all goals are green.
- Amber: Uncertain; adjustments may be needed.
- Red: Off track; reconsider the goal or your approach.

Step 3: Adjust for Next Quarter. For goals in the amber or red zone, or for those without set annual goals, consider these options:

- **Adjust expectations:** Account for the "[Planning Fallacy](#)" by recalibrating your goals.
- **Remove (or lower) goals:** Don't feel ashamed. Be realistic about what's achievable. Reaching your Plan B or C is fine too.
- **Review systems:** Ensure your systems effectively translate goals into daily actions. A [Weekly Review](#) is highly recommended.
- **You still don't have goals?** Start by creating one right now (you can see my personal examples below for inspiration). It doesn't need to be anything too fancy, just go get started with something small!

Bonus Step: Involve others. Extend this exercise to partners - engage your team at work and your spouse or significant other at home. Inclusion fosters appreciation for shared goals and incentivizes others to help with your progress.

Think of this review as a quick pit stop before continuing on your journey.

Effective Personal Sprint Planning: Boosting Productivity with Agile Principles

Today marks the end of my personal challenge: [posting daily on LinkedIn for four weeks straight](#). Why did I put myself through this? Simply put, it made me feel super uncomfortable. A year ago, I had never written publicly. I forced myself to open this newsletter, then post weekly on LinkedIn, and now daily. Why? Because I want to help people, and writing is a great mechanism for that, so I want to make it a strength by getting out of my comfort zone - I've heard that this is where growth happens.

[Side note: I learned that posting something "controversial" can backfire. One post reached 100k+ people but had low engagement, causing LinkedIn to reduce visibility for my new posts this week by more than half. It's frustrating, but it's part of the learning process. Now, I need to rebuild my rapport with the LinkedIn algorithm, so if you could [engage with my recent posts](#), I'd greatly appreciate it.]

Moving on to today's topic: Embracing Agile principles can greatly enhance team productivity, and I believe the same principles can be applied to managing your personal workload. Here's how:

The Theory

Sprint planning is a core component of the [Scrum framework](#) that helps tech teams apply Agile principles to achieve better results. According to "Scrum: The Art of Doing Twice the Work in Half the Time," it involves breaking down large projects into manageable chunks and focusing on short, time-boxed periods called sprints. This method allows for iterative progress and quick adjustments.

Here's how Scrum principles align with managing our weekly workload:

- **Product Roadmap:** Determines the direction, goals, and timeline for a product. Similar to our Personal Goals.
- **Product Backlog:** A prioritized list of work items or features derived from the roadmap. Similar to our Project List.
- **Sprint Backlog:** A subset of the product backlog, broken down into tasks that fit within a sprint's timeframe. Similar to our prioritized Task List after applying the concept of "[Breaking the Lion into Small Kittens](#)."
- **Sprint Planning Meeting:** Where the team decides what to work on during the sprint and how to complete it. Similar to our [Weekly Review process](#), where we decide which tasks to prioritize for the coming week.
- **Sprint Execution:** The period (usually 1-4 weeks) where the team focuses on completing the assigned tasks. Similar to our hustling through those tasks during the week.

- **Sprint Review & Retrospective:** Moments for the team to review completed work and implement improvements. Similar to our weekly reflection (first part of a Weekly Review) or Quarterly Reviews.
- **Refined Backlog:** The updated list of tasks and goals for the next sprint. Similar to the start of a new week.

My Personal Thoughts

Jeff Bezos said, "We are stubborn on vision. We are flexible on details." This captures the essence of effective sprint planning: maintain a long-term vision while being adaptable to changes and uncertainty.

If the full system feels overwhelming, focus on three key Agile principles: (1) Have a clear plan while learning to accept that change will likely come; (2) Obsess about breaking goals into actionable tasks (from goal to projects to weekly tasks); and (3) Reflect and adapt weekly to adjust your plans. These principles will help you stay on track and continuously improve your productivity.

How to Put This Into Practice

1. **Define Your Personal Roadmap:** Set your long-term goals.
2. **Create Your Personal Backlog:** Break goals into specific projects.
3. **Create Your Weekly Backlog:** Break projects into a prioritized list of tasks.
4. **Plan Your Weekly Sprints:** Prioritize your week by moving tasks from your weekly backlog to your calendar.
5. **Execute During the Week:** Focus on completing your assigned tasks.
6. **Reflect, Adjust, and Iterate:** At the end of the Weekly Sprint, review what worked, make adjustments, and improve continuously.

Embrace this iterative process to boost your personal productivity.

The Effective Unicorn: Shohei Ohtani's Secret to Success

I may not be a baseball fan (and technically, I should root for the Angels), but the buzz around [Shohei Ohtani](#) here in Southern California is hard to miss, especially last week when the Dodgers won the World Series. Known as a "unicorn" in baseball, Ohtani is praised as one of the best players ever given how he excels as both a pitcher and hitter.

But what's his secret? Part of his success can be credited to a lesser-known self-development framework called [The Harada Method](#). Here's how it works and why it might just be a game-changer for us to implement.

The Theory

The Harada Method is a goal-setting system that helps you focus on one meaningful, long-term goal (your “North Star”). It was created by Japanese educator [Takashi Harada](#), and it was initially used to motivate struggling students to become top athletes. The method’s backbone is the 64-Chart, which breaks down your main goal into eight supporting areas, each with specific, actionable steps. This approach emphasizes “self-reliance” as a central topic and helps you build daily routines to stay focused on your vision

Visualization and structure are essential to this method. By crafting a plan that combines large aspirations with small, daily actions, we keep the goal alive and manageable. For Ohtani, his 64-Chart included not only athletic training but also supportive habits like regular reading and maintaining a clean environment. These tasks helped build discipline and mental clarity. This approach makes the Harada Method adaptable for personal and professional growth. [Side note: Want to take a peek at Shohei Otani's 64-chart when he was in high school? [Here it is](#) and it is re-mar-ka-ble (to say the least).]

Unlike traditional methods like SMART goals or Kaizen, the Harada Method balances focus with depth. While [SMART goals](#) concentrate on measurable, short-term objectives, the Harada Method works on one long-term goal with smaller, practical steps to support it. Similarly, while [Kaizen](#) emphasizes gradual improvement, the Harada Method encourages a singular, life-shaping focus, with self-reflection and visualization helping to build resilience and motivation over time.

My Personal Thoughts

The Harada Method's long-term planning is inspiring, yet challenging. In today’s fast-paced world, sticking to a single, large goal can feel limiting. Experts suggest that the unpredictable nature of life can make strict goals feel too rigid, as new opportunities may go unnoticed if we hold ourselves too tightly to an initial plan. So, my personal thought (and caution) is that it’s wise to set goals, but that we also need to remain flexible.

This method resembles my “Big Rocks to Projects to Tasks” approach in my course. However, it's much more detailed, with an emphasis on one “ultimate” goal, supported by a visual map and clear paths. This method encourages us to pursue one larger vision but leaves room to adjust. When re-evaluating a goal, I recommend talking with a trusted mentor. This can prevent making poor decisions, like abandoning goals just because they are hard and ensuring our actions are strategic.

How to Put This into Practice

1. **Assess Your Self-Reliance:** Answer these 36 questions to identify how self-reliant you are ([here](#)). This will help you establish a baseline and identify areas for growth.
2. **Choose Your Main Goal:** Reflect on your values and motivations, then select one long-term goal that excites you—whether it's career-related, a health objective, or a creative pursuit. You can even pick a "unicorn"-style goal like Ohtani did.
3. **Create Your 64-Chart:** Place your goal at the center of a 64-Chart. Around it, identify eight supporting areas, like health, learning, skills, and community. For each of these areas, list eight actionable tasks. For example, under "Health," you might list "15 minutes of stretching," or under "Learning," "Read one book per month."
4. **Develop Daily Routines:** Establish routines that support your main goal and smaller tasks. This could include morning workouts, journaling, or study sessions. Each habit should feel achievable and meaningful.
5. **Monitor Your Progress Daily:** Keep a journal to track your daily progress and adjust as needed. Reflecting each day helps clarify what's working and where you may need to pivot.
6. **Revisit and Revise Regularly:** Check in once a month to refine your 64-Chart. Life changes, and your plan can too. This flexibility keeps the method relevant and helps you stay on track.
7. **Get support:** Share your goals with a mentor. Discuss your progress and any potential changes with someone you trust, as this can help you stay grounded and intentional.

Shohei Ohtani is often called a "unicorn" for his unique skills and success. Perhaps what makes him truly unique is the clarity and dedication he applied to reaching his goals. By following this framework, you too can bring your own unicorn-level goal to life.

Effective Annual Reflection: Reflection before Resolution

Effectively Setting Goals (Part 1): Turning Dreams into Doable Actions

As the year comes to an end, I want to build on last week's post [about reflection](#). This week, let's start to focus on planning for next year. Goal setting is a natural next step, but it's also where many of us fail. We set goals that feel inspiring in the moment but quickly fade into frustration. Why does this happen?

Let's break down how to set meaningful goals. Effective goal setting transforms big dreams into meaningful, actionable plans that fuel long-term success.

The Theory

Goals should align with your values. Most New Year's resolutions fall into familiar categories: health, wealth, relationships, and personal and career growth. These themes are universal because they reflect what we value most in life. To set [effective value-based goals](#), start by asking yourself: *What's truly important to me?* For example, if family is a core value, your resolution might be "have family dinner three nights a week." Goals tied to your values feel more meaningful and are easier to stick to.

Understand the difference between [input and output goals](#). Output goals focus on results, like "lose 10 pounds" or "save \$5,000." But results alone can feel overwhelming or out of reach. Input goals focus on the actions you can control, like "meal prep twice a week" or "set up automatic transfers to savings." Breaking big aspirations into manageable actions creates accountability and prevents burnout.

Break goals into projects and tactics. Borrowing from my Amazon experience, a resolution isn't just a goal, it's a system. Transform goals into projects (bigger efforts) and tactics (specific actions). For example, a goal to "get fit" might become a project to "build a sustainable workout routine," with tactics like "join a gym," "schedule workouts," and "track progress."

My Personal Thoughts

Avoid all-or-nothing thinking. Resolutions often fail because we treat them as binary (success or failure). For example, someone aiming to "become a vegetarian" might feel like they've failed after eating one piece of meat. Instead, aim for incremental progress: "eat vegetarian meals three days a week." Progress isn't perfect, and that's okay. Small wins add up to big change over time. Goals should be flexible enough to allow for progress, not perfection. For example, the TED Talk about being a ["weekday vegetarian"](#) stuck with me because it reframes success as incremental improvement rather than an absolute standard.

Goals should have room to grow. Some resolutions won't be finished within a year...and that's okay! I've learned that meaningful goals are often part of a larger journey. If you start the year aiming to improve your fitness, you might discover other areas to expand, like sleep or nutrition. Goals can evolve, and success isn't tied to the calendar. [Sometimes reaching our goals will take longer](#) and that is OK.

How to Put This Into Practice

1. **Identify your core values.** Ask yourself: What matters most? Use these answers as a foundation for your resolutions. Example: If health is a value, set a goal like "take a walk every morning." [Here's some inspiration](#).
2. **Evaluate your current and ideal status for your core values.** *Draft both an ideal and current scenario to see where the greatest gaps are.*
3. **Set input goals alongside output goals.** For instance, instead of just "save \$10,000," commit to "review my budget every week." Focus on where you have the greatest gaps.
4. **Think in increments.** Don't commit to sweeping changes like "go vegan overnight." Instead, try "plant-based meals twice a week" and build from there.
5. **Break goals into projects and tactics.** Turn "get organized" into a project like "declutter my home," with tactics like "clean one drawer per week."
6. **Track progress without judgment.** Focus on consistency rather than perfection. Celebrate small wins, like completing a week's input goals.

Goal setting is about setting yourself up for sustainable progress, not creating impossible expectations. Next week, we'll explore how to make these goals stick through systems and habits.

Effectively Setting Goals (Part 2): Turning Goals Into Systems That Last

Last week, [we explored](#) how to set effective goals by aligning them with your values, focusing on inputs, and avoiding all-or-nothing thinking. But setting the goal is only half the battle. Making it stick is where the real challenge lies. Resolutions often fail not because they're too ambitious, but because they rely solely on willpower alone to sustain them. Instead, the key to lasting change lies in creating systems and habits that turn goals into a natural part of your life.

In this post, we'll explore how to build systems, create momentum, and use habits to make your goals last far beyond January.

The Theory

Systems create sustainable success. James Clear, in [Atomic Habits](#), emphasizes focusing on systems rather than goals. A system is the process you follow daily to reach your goals. For instance, instead of saying "I want to write a book," focus on writing 500 words every day. Systems shift the focus from the outcome to the process, helping us make steady progress even when motivation disappears.

Habits compound over time. Small, consistent actions lead to exponential results. The idea of "[1% better every day](#)" reminds us that even minor improvements add up over weeks and months. Starting with manageable habits (like a five-minute walk or two minutes of journaling) builds momentum without overwhelming us. Repetition turns these small actions into habits that grow naturally.

Plan for obstacles. Systems succeed because they account for setbacks. Use "if-then" planning to stay adaptable: "If I miss a workout, then I will go for a walk." [Sahil Bloom recommends](#) having three goals (A, B, and C) for any area of life. Anticipate missing a goal and ensure you have a fallback plan [Side note: I am not trying to jinx it, but we all do miss goals]

My Personal Thoughts

Habits are my secret weapon. I've seen firsthand how small systems, like writing for 15 minutes every morning, lead to much bigger achievements over time. Success isn't about grand gestures; it's about showing up consistently, even when it feels small. It is important to make sure these habits are [tied to your larger goals](#). [Side note: I've developed such a consistent writing routine that my body almost craves it daily...that's the power of habit!]

Flexibility is key. I've also learned that perfection isn't necessary. There will be weeks when life gets in the way. Missing a day or two doesn't mean you've failed (it means you're human). What matters most is bouncing back and staying committed over the long term.

How to Put This Into Practice

1. **Start with a system, not just a goal.** For example, instead of “read more,” commit to “read 10 pages every night before bed.”
2. **Make habits tiny to start.** Start small, like “five push-ups daily” or “one glass of water before coffee.” Gradual growth is more sustainable.
3. **Use habit stacking.** Link new desired habits to existing routines, like meditating after brushing your teeth or journaling during your morning coffee.
4. **Track consistency.** Use a simple tracker to monitor streaks. Celebrate milestones like a 7-day streak to keep motivation high.
5. **Plan for setbacks.** Life happens. Plan for setbacks. Have a backup plan (Plan B or C), like a 5-minute version of your habit, for tough days.

Systems are the bridge between dreams and action. As you step into 2025, focus on building habits and routines that support steady growth (and plan for them to sometimes fail!).

GROWTH & LEARNING

Effective in being disciplined

I've already completed 30 consecutive weeks delivering this newsletter. (It's hard to believe how quickly time has passed.) Through this journey, I've had the chance to learn about newsletters and content creation, but above all, this has been a test of my self-discipline. There was a particular week when I found myself on a work trip, returning late on a Thursday. Despite exhaustion, I made the decision to go to bed early and wake up at 4 am on Friday to deliver this newsletter. "Why not simply skip a week?" one might inquire. So, below, I'll share the insights I've gained, hoping they may prove beneficial to you as well. Furthermore, I'd like to extend a formal welcome to my newsletter—an acknowledgment I've neglected until now. With over 10,000 of you now receiving this weekly, it seems an opportune moment to do so.

Tips on discipline

I have been training myself to be disciplined for over a decade and sending a weekly newsletter has still been super hard for me. This is what I learned throughout this process:

1. **Acknowledge Small Victories:** What I've realized is that progress often exhibits diminishing returns. While it certainly became more manageable after the initial ten weeks, subsequent improvements were only marginal. Prepare yourself for this reality, as it's a common feature of disciplines that take time to build.
2. **Clarify Your "Why":** Initially, I cited altruism as my motivation, claiming to do this to assist others. While the positive responses truly brighten my day, I've discovered that anchoring oneself solely in the service of others can lead to justifications for skipping or abandoning the task altogether. Consequently, I've adopted a more self-centered "why." I am doing this to get better at writing for an audience. I once jokingly wrote about potentially writing a book and a handful of you recommended books, shared tips, and offered to help. This is now the second thing that keeps me going now. It might take time but practice is always required - the way I see it, if I get to a thousand posts it would be equivalent to writing a 60,000 word book.
3. **Recognize Your Limitations:** Through trial and error, I've come to understand my writing process in three distinct stages: (1) Ideation and research, (2) Unrestricted writing, and (3) Editing and proofreading. I've learned that transitioning smoothly from the first to the second phase requires ample time, and surprisingly, the final stage demands considerable attention. Armed with this awareness, I've embraced various tools to streamline my workflow (cue AI assistance!).
4. **Know your limitations and plan accordingly.** I learned after several tries that I cannot just sit down and "write". I wasn't self aware and my planning wasn't working. Now, I understand that for me writing comes in three parts: (1) Thinking about a topic and doing research; (2) Writing it down without word limits; and (3) Trimming is down and proof reading. I learned that I need time between 1 and 2 for my writing to then be fluid, and that surprisingly the third step takes me a lot of time, so I now leverage tools to help me out (AI to the rescue!)

5. **Embrace Imperfection:** Despite my ongoing battle with pre- and post-publication doubts (perhaps a manifestation of impostor syndrome) I've found peace in a recurring sentiment shared by multiple content creators - ["No one cares for you more than yourself"](#). I've adopted a mantra where I envision my children as the primary audience for my writings. If my efforts can potentially benefit them, and only them, I would still be worth it.

You can apply these learning too. Whether your aspirations involve writing more frequently, adopting a healthier diet, integrating meditation into your routine, embarking on a strength training regimen, or any other endeavor demanding sustained discipline, remember: the crucial step is to begin. Remember that no one really cares that much, get to know your limitations and plan accordingly, establish a compelling personal motivation (while altruism is commendable, self-interest is equally valid), and don't overlook the significance of celebrating incremental victories, for progress is often subtle and easily overlooked.

Effective at Thinking Slow

In memory of Daniel Kahneman

In 2001, my first economics class began with the teacher making the sarcastic remark that "economics is a very precise discipline that relies only on the "minor" assumption that human beings and firms act rationally." The entire class erupted in laughter. How that introduction then led me to become an economist years later still baffles me.

Daniel Kahneman, a psychologist, dedicated his career to understanding this "irrationality" and won a Nobel Prize in Economics for pioneering "Behavioral Economics." He passed away three weeks ago at 90, leaving a significant legacy. Much of what I've learned about self-development can be attributed to his findings. Today's post is dedicated to him and his work, hoping you can appreciate his legacy and apply some of it.

Effective at Thinking Slow

In 2002, Kahneman won a Nobel Prize for developing prospect theory (developed together with [Amos Tversky](#) who passed away in 1996), challenging traditional economic assumptions of rationality. Traditional economic theory assumes that we all make rational choices to maximize utility, but this research demonstrated that this much more complex and often irrational, as our actions are subject to cognitive biases, subjective perceptions, and emotions. Prospect theory mainly explains how we [perceive gains and losses differently](#), leading to suboptimal outcomes. For instance, this is why most of us have a hard time selling stock when we are losing vs. making a profit.

Kahneman's book "[Thinking Fast and Slow](#)" defined [two systems](#) in our minds.

System 1 is our intuitive, automatic mode of thinking, and operates quickly and effortlessly. It is the one that activates when asked what is "2 + 2". However, it's also filled with biases that can lead to irrational behavior, such as [availability bias](#), [anchor bias](#), and [optimism bias](#). System 2 is our analytical, deliberate mode of thinking. It

requires conscious effort and is the one activated when asked what is "47 x 24." As you probably notice, there is a lot of resemblance between these two systems and the analogy I used about all of us being [Homer Simpson or Mr. Spock](#). Despite its flaws, System 1 is in charge in many situations, influencing our decisions and actions without us even realizing it.

Kahneman also shared we have [two selves](#). The experiencing self lives in the present moment, directly experiencing sensations and emotions as they happen. Meanwhile, the remembering self reconstructs past experiences in our minds and shapes our perceptions of happiness based on memory. While the experiencing self finds happiness in immediate pleasures, the remembering self derives happiness from the stories we tell ourselves about our lives. Endings play a crucial role in shaping our memories, often overshadowing the overall quality of an experience. [For example](#), some people had a better story to tell about a 25-minute colonoscopy that ended with low pain than an 8-minute one with fewer overall pain but ending on a peak. This discrepancy between the experiencing and remembering selves creates a challenge in understanding happiness.

Kahneman once asked a crowd to think about their dream vacation. Think of something...ready? OK. Now, consider that all your photos and memories will be erased. Would you pick the same spot? The answer to this would help you understand if you are prioritizing your leisure time for your experiencing or remembering self (I guess Disney Parks relies a lot on our remembering selves).

What actions can you take?

- **Establish decision criteria in advance to minimize bias.** Before you need to make a decision, whether initiating an experiment or selecting a new home, determine and assign a weight to essential factors. Then, objectively evaluate options against them. Otherwise, your answer can be biased by the effort you put on the experiment or the amount of time you toured a particular property.
- **Slow down when making decisions.** Recognize you are surrounded by biases, and conduct a quality control to uncover potential influences. Consider performing a pre-mortem analysis to identify potential failure points (answer the hypothetical question: "If all went wrong, what was the main cause?").
- **Implement mechanisms to engage System 2 in planning.** Utilize methods such as [Weekly Planning](#), [Personal Quarterly Review](#), or Meal Prep Sundays to ensure that critical decisions (what to eat, how to invest, when to do physical activity) are made deliberately.
- **Make it easy for System 1.** Eliminate obstacles for desired behaviors and introduce barriers for undesired ones. For example, keep gym clothes by your bed for morning exercise, or store chocolate out of sight.
- **Apply the peak-end rule to leave a lasting impression.** Aim to conclude activities on a positive note, whether it's a presentation at work or a family day-trip. This is what all the participants' minds will remember the most about the experience. Transparently, I always try to end presentations or written pieces with jokes to make the concept more memorable.

Effective at Personal Decision-Making: Three techniques that help with personal decisions

[Last week](#), I presented the topic of Behavioral Economics, recommending to slow down our decision-making and to establish decision criteria beforehand to minimize bias. This week, I want to explore the topic of decision-making a bit further, as it is indeed often recurrently irrational. I started writing the lines below and noticed there was a lot of content to cover, so I have split it in two: this week I will cover personal decisions and next week I'll cover work/project related decisions.

Where to attend college? What to major in? What job to take? Should I get an MBA? Which city should I move to? Is this the right time to get married? - These are all questions a lot of us have faced. Keep reading to get a bit more context, and recommended next steps.

Effective at Personal Decision-Making

Bad decisions can often be traced back to lack of planning or due diligence. The truth is that some of these big decisions happen early in life and we just have no clue. We don't end up evaluating the benefits and costs of all of our options, we don't talk to others to seek their opinion, we don't evaluate all possible outcomes. For instance, according to this [survey done to Americans who attended college](#), 81% chose their college major based on love for the subject as opposed to a higher potential income, but then 6.2 out of every 10 people later regret their decision and 65% end up having an occupation that's not related to their major. [Note to self: I am adding "Effective decision-making" to the curriculum of my fictitious "Things they should teach in schools (but don't)" Program. Also included: Personal Financial Planning, Time Management, Sales, Dealing with rejection, etc...Sign up [here](#)].

But some other times, bad decisions happen because our own brain sabotages us. Just like [Daniel Kahneman](#) explained, our choices are often complex and irrational due to cognitive biases and subjective perceptions. For instance, [status-quo bias](#) incentivizes us to maintain the current situation even if new ones could be better, [confirmation bias](#) encourages us to find evidence that just confirms what we think is the right option to begin with, or [optimism bias](#) makes us think that although there's data proving something, it will simply "not happen to us" (e.g. over-costs when doing a house project).

Emotions can also sabotage our decision-making. The "[Somatic Marker Hypothesis](#)" proposes that emotions strongly influence our decisions through bodily sensations (or somatic markers), as they can be associated with external events. These feeling in our bodies (such as disgust, rapid heartbeat or anxiety) can be primary (innate) or secondary (acquired), and affect our decision-making process. I guess that's why they say never to go grocery shopping while hungry.

How to make decisions effectively?

There are so many possible tips here, but I will share three that have really helped me:

1. Know your decision-making style. Take this [Problem-Solver Profile](#) (PSP) and determine which one of the five different archetypes you are (adventurer, detective, listener, thinker, and visionary). Then, you can play to your strengths and be mindful of your blind spots. This test is only eight questions but does require you to create a login.

2. List the important criteria in advance. I was first introduced to this concept by a [case study](#) I know, it's quite random that a table in an appendix of one of dozens of papers had such an impact, but it did. This person had to choose between jobs, and he acknowledged that his decision-making process would be biased after the interview processes, so he selected the criteria that is important to him beforehand and have it a weight (all criteria added to 100%). After receiving offers, he evaluated each one by giving a score of 1 to 5 (best to worst) per criteria. I have used this same framework to choose jobs, roles, and even where to move during the pandemic when my family decided to leave Seattle and basically could "move anywhere." (oh how quickly that got reversed still baffles me). Here is [my personal example](#).

3. Apply second order thinking. We sometimes make decisions thinking about our present selves, but a lot of things that yield really high results are not really that great for our present-self (first order thinking), but end up being amazing for our future-self (second order thinking) - e.g. working out, eating healthy.

- **The 10-10-10 Rule:** Draw a table (digitally or physically) with three columns (10 minutes, 10 months, 10 years), create a row per option and then write how each options affect the things that are important to you (family, health, finances, etc.)
- **Fake make a decision:** A mentor gave me this tip when I was between two roles. Pick one and write the email accepting it (just don't send it, but trick your mind as you did). Go to sleep, and see how you feel the next days. Did you regret it?
- **Ask someone who has gone through something like this before:** It will be difficult for others to give you actual recommendations, and if they do, please take them with a pinch of salt. Instead, ask them about what were their greatest surprises as time passed.

Effective at Minimizing Regret: My next move after Amazon

The Theory

The **Regret Minimization Framework** was created by Jeff Bezos to justify his decision to leave a VP-level job on Wall Street to launch an online bookstore.

Bezos imagined himself at age 80, looking back on his life and realizing he would regret not seizing the internet opportunity more than leaving his stable, high-paying job. This thought process focused on minimizing potential regrets by prioritizing long-term fulfillment over short-term security. This eventually led him to leave Wall Street, move to Seattle, and found Amazon in his garage. His framework highlights the importance of considering future regrets to make bold, life-changing decisions (something we all know worked out well for him).

We overestimate the effect of potential losses and then regret our decisions later. This phenomenon is extensively covered by [Kahneman](#) and Tversky's [Prospect Theory](#). It outlines that people weigh potential losses more heavily than equivalent gains; however, evidence also suggests that most people regret inaction more than potential failure. In "[The Top Five Regrets of the Dying](#)," it is revealed that many people, in their final moments, express profound regret over not having the courage to live true to their dreams. This insight aligns with psychological studies, suggesting that the enduring pain of "what could have been" often follows us until the end of our lives.

Our default mode is to just keep the current course. As I previously mentioned, we all have [Two Selves](#), and if we don't do the proper (hard) self-reflection, it is easy for our Doer (Homer Simpson)-self to make the decisions, as opposed to our Planner (Mr. Spock)-self. Our Doer-self doesn't like uncertainty and will likely focus on not rocking the boat if "things are going well."

My Personal Thoughts

If you follow your dreams, you better have a good backup plan. I believe there is a tendency to idolize stories like Jeff Bezos' as extremely risky moves and disregard some important facts. In Jeff's case, he had a VP-level Wall Street job he left on good terms, a degree in computer science from Princeton (at probably the best time in history), was still young (30), and is estimated to have a [high IQ](#). This is not to minimize the fact that he took a risk but to point out that, if he failed, he still had many opportunities to fall back on.

How to Put This into Practice

So, should you just drop everything and follow your dreams? Well, it's complicated. My recommendation, as usual, is to "[break the lion into small kittens](#)" by avoiding drastic and passionate decisions and playing the long game by following the steps below:

Step 1: Discover the thing you are likely to regret not acting on (aka Your Lion).

Reflect on the things you constantly think about or that you enjoy doing in your spare time.

Step 2: Break the lion into small kittens and act on one. Break this big project into as many parts as you can think of and find the lowest hanging fruit you can act on.

Step 3: Once you nail that, add the next kitten.

Step 4: Keep going until you get to 20% of your time. [The Mayo Clinic](#) suggest that fulfillment is maximized when you spend 20% of your time working on your passion; beyond that, the rest starts to be marginal increases. I propose how to carve out time in [this post](#).

Step 5: Keep scaling until you feel comfortable making the jump. When you get to Step 4, you'll probably either confirm your aspirations or burst your bubble. So, this final jump might never come, and that's OK. If you do decide to take this step, make sure you have proof and something to fall back on.

Bonus section: Sharing how this applies to my personal story

I usually end the post here (at about a 2-3 minute read), but as I left last week on a cliffhanger (not letting you know what my next step is) I am writing this bonus section to explain how this theory applies to my own story and what my next move is:

My own path:

Step 1: I love public speaking and developing others. I wasn't doing much of that in 2016.

Step 2: I started giving a training to whoever showed up. In 2017, I scheduled a meeting room at the Apollo building in Seattle, and created an email list for people interested in taking a course. First training was to 20 people, last in person one was to 400.

Step 3: I automated my presentations. In 2021, after tens of thousands had already taken my presentations, I realized it wasn't fun anymore to do the same presentation over and over. I focused on automating and dedicate my time to do workshops for teams.

Step 4: I built a newsletter. I noticed how the email list had grown so much and I wasn't sending anything, so I started a newsletter and dialed down the workshops (still maintaining this as 20% of my time)

Step 5: The time is now. I have validated my idea, with a course lineup that have proven to have saved 2.75 hours a week to tens of thousands, and a newsletter that just passed three thousand (very) active subscribers. I have a Plan B, with my wife still having an income, and what I consider to be a strong network in case I want to return to the corporate world.

What am I offering now

I just created a new company "Effective LLC" to start offering what used to be my side gig to everyone. My main goal is to ensure people are building the right foundations for a successful career, making them feel in control. Current lineup:

1. **This newsletter:** I will keep posting every Friday, share it with others using the referral link at the bottom of this email. [3k+ subscribed]
2. **[Sign up to be a Founding Member.](#)** I am building a program for people who want to feel more in control of your professional journey based on insights from my years training others. Share your info [here](#) to become an early adopter. [100+ requests received]
3. **Request to train your team.** For years, I received several weekly requests to train teams and I had to politely decline 99% of them. Now, if you want your team to be more effective, you can reply to this email with your request - Participants has reported 2.75 hours of time saved per week after taking the master course. That's 33 minutes daily, forever. [Three requests received].
4. **Book a 1:1 session with me.** If you consider that your needs require immediate attention, you can reply to this email with your request [Two requests received].

Effective at Finding Meaning: The Power of Helping Others

I've been focusing on growing my online presence, and this week, one of my posts [is going viral](#). It's incredible to see how certain content resonates with so many people. (If we're not already connected on LinkedIn, don't hesitate to [add me](#)!) I'm also fortunate to be spending more time teaching and coaching high performers. One recurring theme I hear from them is: they've achieved major milestones (promotions, raises, leadership roles) yet they find themselves asking, "Is this it? What's next?"

I've been there too. After the initial excitement fades, a sense of emptiness can follow. This led me to dive deeper into the idea of meaning, particularly how helping others brings fulfillment beyond personal success. I hope you find this reading as *meaningful* as I found writing it.

The Theory

True meaning comes not from personal achievements but from helping others and being part of something bigger than ourselves. Most of us are familiar with [Maslow's hierarchy of needs](#), where self-actualization (becoming the best version of oneself) is the top goal. But that wasn't the end of Maslow's work. Before his death, he explored an even higher level: **self-transcendence**. This concept didn't get published widely, leaving it as "[the forgotten pinnacle of human development](#)." Self-actualization focuses on individual fulfillment; however, self-transcendence is about connecting with others, contributing to society, and going beyond the self.

Maslow's final insight: True meaning comes from "transcending" personal ambition. It's about shifting from "How can I maximize my potential?" to "How can I serve something larger than myself?" Viktor Frankl's "[Man's Search for Meaning](#)," emphasizes that those who found meaning (especially by serving others) were more resilient, even in the harshest circumstances. Frankl, like Maslow, proposed that meaning doesn't come from personal success, but from contributing to something beyond the self.

Others echo this: The book "[Flourish](#)" highlights that meaning is key to well-being and that it comes from being part of something greater (a cause, a family, or a community). Clayton Christensen's "[How Will You Measure Your Life?](#)" also makes the case that real success isn't about material gains or promotions, but the positive impact we have on others.

But meaning actually is not the same as happiness. According to multiple psychological and philosophical frameworks, happiness is temporary, but meaning involves a deeper sense of purpose and significance that comes from contributing beyond ourselves, and is what sustains us through life's ups and downs. It's the difference between short-term pleasure and long-term fulfillment.

My Personal Thoughts

Personally, I write this newsletter for two reasons (I have [shared my "why" before](#)): to help others, but also for my personal growth. Writing helps me process my thoughts, refine ideas, and improve my writing skills. It feels good to accomplish something. But I also write to serve others. If I kept all this learning to myself, I'd miss out on the deeper fulfillment that comes from sharing it with others. At the same time, I've realized that focusing only on helping others can feel hollow at times, if there's no personal sense of personal accomplishment that goes with it. Ultimately, it's a balance!

I recently heard in [a TED Talk](#) that "being a part of a story that is not yours provides meaning to your life." While we're often told to be the "main character" in our own stories, it is also really important to play supporting roles in others' lives. By helping others grow while still gaining personal satisfaction, I've found a richer sense of fulfillment. It's not about choosing between self-actualization and self-transcendence; in my opinion, it's about balancing both. [Side note: This is why it makes my day when readers share how this newsletter has helped them achieve something. Please keep them coming.]

How to Put This into Practice

1. **Help others without expecting anything in return:** Reach out to mentor someone, volunteer, or simply offer a colleague some support.
2. **Share your personal growth:** Turn your learning into value for others. Whether it's industry insights or personal finance tips, summarize and share your notes in a way that helps others.
3. **Find what blends meaning with achievement:** For example, if you want to improve your presentation skills, try teaching part-time to serve others while honing your craft.
4. **Connect with a community:** Meaning often comes from being part of something larger. Find or create communities where you can contribute and grow together.
5. **Bonus - Share the content you consume:** Even if it's not related to personal development. Whether it's NBA highlights or fashion trends, package what you've learned and share it with others through a blog or social media. I promise that with time, this will lead you close to balancing meaning and happiness.

Effective with Money: Building Foundations for Financial Growth

Introduction

Talking about money might seem a little off-track from my usual topics, but personal and career growth depends on a strong financial foundation. Whether for freedom, stability, or our dreams, money is essential (even if we'd rather not think of it that way).

While personal finance can get complex (especially in the U.S. with 401(k)s and other strategies), I want to focus on principles that apply almost anywhere. Here's a look at key ideas to help you take charge of your financial path (and just to clarify, I am not a financial planner, I just read a lot of theory and try to share it in a consolidated manner every week).

The Theory

Automation and simplification make consistency easy. One of the best ways to simplify our finances is to automate. In "[I Will Teach You to Be Rich](#)," Ramit Sethi suggests automating transfers to savings, investments, and other goals so that saving becomes a "default." This frees up time and energy to focus on the bigger picture, rather than managing every transaction. The idea? Automate what matters so you don't need to make daily decisions on where your money goes.

Use the 50-30-20 Rule for mindful spending. Mindful spending is all about aligning expenses with values, and the [50-30-20 rule](#) is a helpful guide. It suggests spending 50% of income on needs, 30% on wants, and 20% on savings. *The Algebra of Wealth* and similar frameworks encourage finding satisfaction in simplicity and focusing on what brings lasting value. With this balance, you're able to prioritize savings while still allowing for flexibility and enjoyment in your spending.

Diversification and time in the market. Growing wealth depends on investing, and diversification (spreading investments across different assets) reduces risk. A popular rule is the "[60/40 rule](#)," which suggests investing 60% in stocks and 40% in bonds (it actually suggests adjusting the bond percentage to your age, which I think makes a ton of sense, but I do understand why [it has some detractors](#)). "[The Simple Path to Wealth](#)" advocates for low-cost index funds like the S&P 500, which have a strong track record. While it's tempting to try to "time the market," experts advise aiming to spend "time in the market" to let investments grow. Diversified, low-cost funds are a steady, reliable way to build wealth. [Side note: If you earn [RSUs](#), you are probably highly invested in one stock, so take a close look to see if you are where you want to be.]

My Personal Thoughts

Money is a shared household goal. I believe financial planning should be a team effort within a household. Money is a [major cause of stress in relationships](#) (often leading to divorce), so having open discussions and shared investment and spending goals is essential, even if one person makes more or manages the bills. Joint decisions lead to less stress and more alignment.

Time and Money: Our two most precious assets. I see a lot of similar patterns in how we manage both. We often say we value things like health or education, but how often do we actually spend time or money on them? Managing time and money follows the same principle: Make a clear plan that aligns with your values and stick with it.

How to Put This into Practice

1. **Automate Key Financial Actions:** Call your bank representative and set up recurring transfers for savings and investments.
2. **Apply the 50-30-20 Rule:** Review your budget based on this split (50% for needs, 30% for wants, 20% for savings) and adjust if needed.
3. **Establish an Emergency Fund in a [high-yield savings account](#):** Aim to save at least 3 months' worth of expenses to protect against unexpected costs. Choose a high-yield account to maximize returns.
4. **Diversify Your Investments:** Consider a mix of stocks and bonds that matches your age and risk tolerance. ETFs like VTSAX or VOO are good low-cost options (and review your RSUs).
5. **Review and Adjust Regularly:** Set aside time each month or quarter to stay aligned with your financial plan and make adjustments as needed.

Money is a tool, not the goal. Let's make it work for us, not the other way around.

Effectively Creative: Small Creative Habits for Big Results

As a kid, creativity came so naturally - I painted, wrote poems, and came up with short stories. But somewhere along the way, someone noticed I was good at math. Fast-forward a decade, and I had a degree in Economics and Finance, with my creative spark largely left behind.

Recently, I've reconnected with creativity by exploring things like writing (and designing) daily on LinkedIn (thanks to those who are [supporting](#)!). These creative tasks have energized me and brought clarity I didn't know I was missing. Studies show creative hobbies can improve focus by as much as 29%, making us more productive and reducing stress. I strongly believe that creativity isn't something you're "born with" - it's a skill you can grow. So today, I challenge you to try a new creative activity. Let's explore how to make it happen.

The Theory

A beginner's mind creates the freedom to explore (without needing to succeed).

The [Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind](#), describes this mindset as focusing on the experience rather than the outcome. In creative practice, a beginner's mind lets us engage in the process and frees us from needing to be "good" or "experienced." We rediscover curiosity and openness by letting go of the pressure for results, focusing on "enjoying the ride."

Creative confidence can be built by everyone, step by step. Creativity isn't reserved for a select few; it's a skill that grows with practice and patience. The book [Creative Confidence](#) emphasizes that we all have creative potential. Building confidence through small creative acts, like sketching or brainstorming, shows us that creativity doesn't require innate talent, it just requires the willingness to try and trust the process. Each small success builds on itself, creating a foundation of confidence we can carry into new creative task.

Sustained creative energy comes from consistent, small acts. [The Accidental Creative](#) explains that creativity is an energy we need to regularly tap into. By engaging in small creative acts (e.g. writing a paragraph, or taking a few minutes to brainstorm) we keep this energy flowing. Regularly feeding our creative energy keeps us open to inspiration and prevents burnout. The result is a steady flow of new ideas and a habit of creativity that sustains itself.

My Personal Thoughts

Playing with kids is one of the best ways to reconnect with creativity. As a parent, I'm constantly reminded of the power of play. Playing with my kids (building with Legos, coloring, or assembling a puzzle) does wonders to free up my mind and reconnect with imagination. Pretend play and games are amazing ways to reset and

get into a fresh mindset. I strongly recommend these simple activities if you're looking for a way to decompress and spark new ideas.

Creativity can be cultivated, no matter where you're starting. Over the past year, I've reintroduced creativity into my life in many ways, from taking stand-up comedy classes to exploring writing and embracing the "creator economy." Each of these has challenged me to think in new ways, using parts of my brain that may have been asleep for a while. These new pursuits have reminded me that creativity is not about being "artistic" but about being willing to try new things and explore. I'm learning that we don't have to be "creative" to create - we just need to be open to learning.

How to Put This into Practice

1. **Start small:** Pick an easy, low-pressure activity like doodling, baking, or building a puzzle. Focus on the process, not perfection. [See here](#) if you want inspiration.
2. **Embrace curiosity:** Approach tasks with no expectations. Watch a "how to" video on YouTube to get started.
3. **Take daily creative steps:** Spend a few minutes each day on a creative habit to build confidence and momentum.
4. **Use creativity to recharge:** Take quick, energizing breaks. Try building something with [Legos](#), arranging flowers, or writing random thoughts down, to spark focus and energy.
5. **Connect with others:** Join a class or group to share ideas and find inspiration through collaboration.
6. **Play together:** Use activities like games, crafts, or storytelling with kids, friends, or family to spark imagination and fun.
7. **Reflect often:** Revisit your creative journey and celebrate progress to stay motivated and inspired.

Creativity is within all of us. Let's start small and see where it leads.

MINDSET & WELL-BEING

The Effective Night Owl: Tips for those who cannot wake up at 5am

Despite there being statistically the same number of "Early Risers" as "Night Owls," society has collectively decided that to be productive, we should be waking up early. Today's writing is dedicated to those who aren't wired to be able to wake up early. I am personally passionate about ending this misrepresentation, so if you are a "Night Owl" (i.e. you cannot fall asleep before 11pm) and are interested in learning personalized tips from others like you, simply **reply to this email with a tip that might benefit other owls (e.g. your morning or night-time routines), or just say "hi"**. If you are an "early riser," continue reading so you empathize more with your Owl friends and colleagues, and can share the recommendations below with them.

The Effective Night Owl

We all belong to one of three main chronotypes. Ever wondered why some people are full of energy and enthusiasm early in the morning, while others take a while to get there? It's all about [chronotypes](#) – the unique patterns that dictate our peak alertness and preferred sleep times. There are various labels out there, but the experts agree on three main groups. **(1) The Early Risers (Larks):** roughly 10-30% of the population joyfully rise with the sun, usually waking up around 6 am, hitting their energy peak by late morning. **(2) The Night Owls:** also 10-30% of people identifies as "evening types", finding their groove in the late hours. Owls typically wake up around 8 am, with their energy peaking in the late afternoon and evening. **(3) Middle Birds:** The majority, around 40-80%, fall somewhere in between, showcasing characteristics of both morning and evening preferences, painting a fascinating tapestry of our internal rhythms. It is common for these middle crew to still lean towards and identify more with one the sides ([click here](#) to learn what is your chronotype).

How did we all end up having different chronotypes? This is deeply ingrained into the fabric of our genes (the [PER3 gene](#) to be precise). Evolutionary theorists suggest that having a mix of chronotypes made us more likely to survive as a species as we took "shifts" protecting the collective. As much as our genes set the stage, external elements like study/work schedules and culture can shape our chronotypes ([See American moms](#) in Spain, surprised about the playgrounds being full at 7-9pm) . So, the next time you catch yourself wondering why you cannot seem to be operative first thing in the morning, remember – it's not just personal preference or "laziness"; it's a symphony of biology, genetics, and the daily rhythms of life.

Society has labelled "early risers" as the most productive and that is not fair.

Despite there being the same percentage of the people who are predisposed to be "Larks" or "Owls", in the world of productivity, the cultural mantra of "early to rise" has been labelled as a universal path to success. This cultural bias tends to overshadow the fact that there is proof the "Night Owls" can be [more creative](#) and even more [intelligent overall](#). However, they do have an uphill battle against them as we have structured everything for early risers (e.g. school starting at 8am, the 9-to-5 workday) and have placed an overall stigma to those who wake up later. This has led to "Night Owls" struggling with more health issues and [report lower levels of happiness](#).

We need to change the narrative. Countless of self-proclaimed social media productivity gurus have glorified waking up at the crack of dawn as their number of predictor for success. Books like "The 5 AM Club" have created a compelling narrative around the transformative power of having a "Victory Hour" (with focus on exercise, reflection, and learning) in the early morning hours. However, it is essential to recognize that none of the things these people do early in the morning cannot be tackled at another time of the day. A "9pm Club" could be equally as effective, but a concept like this is nowhere to be seen on the bookshelves.

What can you do?

1st: Reply to this email if you want to continue exploring the topic of productivity for "Night Owls".

2nd: Based on my own research, there are three strategies a "Night Owl" can follow to boost their productivity:

1. **Convert:** This is where little by little you start forcing yourself to wake up earlier. [Here](#) are some great tips.
2. **Disrupt:** This is about thinking outside of the box. Ask for permission to start your day later. So you can do exactly the same as early risers do but 2-3 hours later. You can ask for permission to start your day at 10-11am and end at 6-7pm or you need to find a job that allows you to do that (maybe working West Coast times while leaving on the East Coast is a good idea)
3. **(Recommended) Adapt:** Try to adapt your hours to best suit the normal conventions of society. Know your own body and find the right time to do the things you know are important. For instance, my proposal for adapting the 5AM club for a Night Owls looks something like this:

The "90min-9PM Club":

1. **Exercise:** Start by dedicating the first 20 minutes to gentle physical activity, perhaps yoga or a leisurely walk under the moonlit sky (I am aware there is [some debate](#) about working out at night, but just give it a try!)
2. **Reflection:** Allocate another 20 minutes for mindful reflection – journaling thoughts, setting intentions, and acknowledging achievements.
3. **Learning:** Dedicate 20 minutes to learning, whether it's reading a book, watching an educational video, or engaging in an online course.
4. **Remove friction from your morning.** Spend 30min planning your following day. Take out the clothes you are going to wear and prep something to eat for breakfast. Do a [#Closing Shift](#) to have a clean home at the start of the following day. Review and plan tomorrow's calendar.

You can accomplish the same level of productivity at night too, it just requires some creativity and willingness to go against the current.

Effective at Being Lucky: Practical Tips for Cultivating Intentional Fortune

I once resented being labeled "lucky" for achievements in school or at work, as I thought it overlooked the amount of effort I was putting in; now, I embrace it. I recognize that everything involves having some uncontrollable and unpredictable luck, but that said luck can also be intentionally influenced by our own efforts. My favorite insight is from a 1978 book widely quoted since. In the post below, I explore four types of luck and suggest actions to intentionally shape our own luck.

Effective at being Lucky

There are four types of luck. Popularized by [Marc Andreessen](#) in 2007, echoed by [Naval Ravikant](#) in 2019, and illustrated by [Sahil Bloom](#) on LinkedIn in 2023, the concept of four types of luck originates from Dr. James Austin's book "[Chase, Chance, and Creativity: The Lucky Art of Novelty](#)" (1978, updated in 2003). These types, simplified as luck, are:

1. **Blind Luck:** Unpredictable and beyond control. In the words of Prof. Scott Galloway's "The most important factor in determining a person's future is when and where they are born."
2. **Luck from Motion:** Involves exploring opportunities through proactive efforts. Echoing the Roman proverb "Fortune favors the bold," and [Charles Kettering](#)'s saying "I have never heard of anyone stumbling on something sitting down.", this type of luck mainly derives from hard work.
3. **Luck from Awareness:** Rooted in deep domain understanding, enabling the recognition of potential opportunities. As Naval Ravikant puts it "You become very good at spotting luck. If you are very skilled in a field, you will notice when a lucky break happens in that field. When other people who aren't attuned to it won't notice".
4. **Luck from Uniqueness:** Favors those with distinctive attributes, drawing specific luck based on personal qualities that are somehow rare.

[Qi Lu](#) (the most interesting person in Silicone Valley that nobody talks about) exemplifies a blend of luck types. His exceptional intellect (Blind Luck) didn't allow him to even take the entrance exam for his American dream. He still committed to hard work (Motion Luck). One rainy Sunday, a friend invited him to sit in for an absent attendee at a lecture. Qi's insightful questions led for the lecturer to offer him a full scholarship at Carnegie Mellon (Awareness Luck). This then led Qi to become an Executive Vice President at Microsoft, COO of Baidu, and Head of Y Combinator China. He was "lucky" because if it wouldn't have rained that day, he would have rode his bike home and never attended the lecture, or as he puts it: "Luck is like a bus...If you miss one, there's always the next one. But if you're not prepared, you won't be able to jump on".

How to increase your luck?

1. **Embrace Blind Luck:** Acknowledge the uncontrollable aspects of life. Learn to recognize and appreciate serendipity.
2. **Optimize Luck of Motion:** Challenge the glorification of "hustle culture" by ensuring your hard work aligns with valuable goals. Beware of the "[Trap Zone](#)" (Efficient but Ineffective); prioritize effectiveness (doing the right things) before motion/efficiency (doing the things right).
3. **Enhance Luck of Awareness:**
 - Network actively to broaden [exposure](#). Set goals for meeting new people, as increased interaction with experts strengthens your own expertise.
 - Dedicate time to skill development (daily 30 minutes or weekly 1 hour). Cultivate deep knowledge in your field.
4. **Cultivate Luck of Uniqueness:**
 - Synthesize ideas by documenting thoughts. You likely consume tons of information (books, podcasts), writing down your main insights will help connect dots effectively.
 - Craft an [image](#) of being authentic and reliable. People value uniqueness, but more so reliability.
 - Improve communication skills, ensuring your talents are perceived as effectively as they are possessed.

Effective at Managing Stress: Why feeling stressed isn't always bad

Picture a challenging work meeting where questions intensify, and your answers fall short. Your palms get sweaty, knees weak, arms heavy (channeling my inner [Marshall Mathers](#) here). We all have been taught to despise that feeling and label it as something that is negative for our health. But what if I told you that not all stress is negative? Explore below the positive aspects of stress and discover how to apply its benefits effectively.

Effective at Managing Stress

Our body's response to stress is not entirely within our control. In "[Why Zebras Don't Get Ulcers](#)," Robert Sapolsky explores the impact of stress on physical, chemical, and social well-being, distinguishing between acute and chronic stress. The book emphasizes our ability to handle short-term stress but highlights the challenges posed by persistent modern stress. The metaphorical title highlights how zebras rapidly eliminate stress, contrasting with humans who often hold on to it, leading to chronic stress, affecting cardiovascular and brain health. [A study](#) in the National Bureau of Economic Research linked higher student stress and cortisol levels to poverty and crime, revealing cultural factors can also influence our body's reaction to stress.

Stress comes in two forms: (Di)stress and (Eu)stress. Neuroscientist [Anne-Laure Le Cunff notes](#) that (Di)stress can harm mental health and hinder productivity, while (Eu)stress acts as a positive force, propelling us towards peak performance and facilitating a state of Flow. To understand (Eu)stress, think about the type of stress we like (and even voluntarily pay money to experience) such as roller coaster rides or scary movies. We enjoy that type of (Eu)stress because it is transitory and safe, as we are under control at all times, feeling excited, as opposed to anxious.

Believing in the harmful effects of stress significantly influences its actual impact on health. [A 2012 study](#) monitoring 28,000 US adults for 8 years found that those perceiving stress as negative and then experiencing higher levels of stress, increased their risk of premature death by 43%. Conversely, individuals with equally high stress levels but a positive perception did not experience any impact on their mortality rates. A Harvard Stress Test further revealed that re-framing stress cues as positive can alter the body's response, preventing blood vessels to contract, which can lead to cardiovascular impact.

Case study: Patrick Mahomes. In the Super Bowl overtime, Mahomes exhibited a calm demeanor that surprised me, especially taking into consideration I was standing up while not even following the sport at all. Well, insights from his [Whoop health monitor](#) unveiled a pattern: his heart rate peaks when watching his teammates defend, but significantly lowers when he takes charge as the Quarterback. This shift from feeling (di)stress as a spectator to (eu)stress in control of the outcome reflects his ability to manage stress effectively.

What do we do with this information?

1. **Don't try to avoid stress altogether.** A completely stress-free life can lead to missed opportunities for growth and improvement and overall sense of emptiness or lack of purpose. What all the experts recommend is actually balanced amounts of stress (you need to find your own balanced dose).
2. **Embrace (Eu)stress:**
 1. **Link your stress to a goal to convince yourself it's not bad.** For instance, next time you are stressed about a work meeting or a discussion with your kid, think about how this is aligned with your goal of becoming a better leader and a better parent.
 2. **Cultivate a growth mindset.** After finishing a stressful situation, always seek for feedback. Remember you are playing a long game and the negatives are mainly learning opportunities.
3. **Deal with (Di)stress:**
 1. **Detect the source of your distress and create a prevention plan.** This can lead to "[saying no](#)" next time around, or the need to develop new skills that will prevent the situation from happening again.
 2. **Building supportive relationships.** Just complaining to a trusted peer (using them as a sounding board), or getting a coach or mentor to hear you out, can be helpful to "get it out of your chest"
 3. **Practice mindfulness and gratitude.** These are great ways to regulate your balance easier and avoid chronic stress. Remember that just [a deep breath can help in the most challenging of times](#).

If you fear that the feeling of (di)stress is starting to be chronic, please seek professional support.

Effective at Celebrating: How Celebration Shapes our Culture

I'm still exploring the wonders of Japan, twelve days into discovering new places, foods, and cultural norms with my family. After all your engagement with my recent post on [Ikigai](#), I debated about what to write next. There are numerous aspects of Japanese culture that offer lessons in effectiveness, but I've chosen to explore one that particularly surprised me during my work with a team in Japan about a year ago: Japanese Holidays.

Effective at Celebrating

Several Japanese concepts promote effectiveness. In addition to [Ikigai](#), there are multiple other concepts that mostly embrace imperfection and impermanence as roads to resilience and self-discovery. Among these, my favorites include "[Kintsugi](#)," illustrating the beauty of imperfection through repairing broken pottery with gold, "[Kaizen](#)," encouraging continuous improvement (adopted by many operations teams but easily applicable to self-development), and "[Wabi-sabi](#)," which finds beauty in life's natural cycles of growth and decay ("wabi" = less is more, and "sabi" = attentive melancholy).

However, today I want to highlight Japanese Holidays. This is something I believe to to be playing a strong part in shaping the exceptional values and culture I've experienced during my stay here the past 12 days.

- **Japanese holidays reflect a respect for age, ancestors, and family traditions.** Keiro-no-Hi (Respect for the Aged Day) a long weekend in September when people go back home to pay respect to the elderly. Obon, an annual celebration of ancestors and their spirits; and the Spring and Autumn equinoxes (Shunbun no Hi) where families visit temples and participate in rituals passed to them by ancestors.
- **On the opposite end, there are celebrations honoring the youth.** Coming of Age Day (Seijin no Hi), celebrates young people coming into adulthood, and Children's Day (Kodomo no Hi), honors happiness and well-being of children and emphasizing the role of younger generations in shaping the future.
- **Other holidays honor culture, nature, and health.** Culture Day (Bunka no Hi), Marine Day (Umi no Hi), Greenery Day (Midori no Hi), and Sports Day (Taiiku no Hi) celebrate Japan's cultural heritage, environmental preservation, and the importance of a healthy lifestyle.

Our celebrations shape us. Sara Blakely, founder of Spanx, [attributes her success to celebrating failure](#), or as she puts it: "Celebrating not trying instead of celebrating the outcome." Similarly, companies also celebrate innovation by dedicating specific time out of their normal working hours towards thinking "out of the box"; for instance, Google has a 20% Project Time, LinkedIn has 10% InDay projects, and Intel has Innovation Time Offs - ITOs.

What do you celebrate? Celebration in Japanese culture promotes respect for elders, family values, youth, environmental consciousness, and a healthy lifestyle. Over time, we can all end up finding importance to what we celebrate. I propose you try the following:

1. **Determine your main 3-5 Personal/Family Values:** [Here is a list of 20](#) for inspiration.
2. **Set ways to celebrate them.** For instance, if one of your values is "gratitude," try keeping a journal, or creating a day of the week where you go around the table "thanksgiving-style" during dinner (i.e. Thankful Thursdays).
3. **Volunteer to set your team's Quarterly Celebrations.** Usually, teams set annual goals, making it difficult to celebrate during the year. Think beyond your output, and consider celebrating the cultural traits you want your team to have (e.g. failing/innovation, understanding your customers, etc.). Propose to celebrate those with real examples.
4. **When was the last time you celebrated something?** Candidly, this is one of my biggest regrets as I look back. We are all too busy too often that we sometimes forget to celebrate along the way. Even a good presentation at work should be worth celebrating.

Effective Movement: How to Maintain a Productive Lifestyle

I've challenged myself to post on LinkedIn daily, experimenting with various topics and tones to see what resonates. I tried a ["controversial" approach](#) that got over 93,000 impressions but did spark some negativity. I meant well, what do you think?

This week, returning to [these productivity tips](#) that resonated with me, next in line is to "Move!" I'm no health expert and not in peak physical condition myself, but I have researched heavily on the topic, so I hope my findings can be insightful for you.

The Theory

Movement is crucial for maintaining a productive lifestyle. Books like "[Spark](#): The Revolutionary New Science of Exercise and the Brain" and "[The Happiness Advantage](#)" show that exercise boosts brain health, enhances cognitive flexibility, and increases endorphins, reducing stress and anxiety. A Stanford study also found that walking improves divergent thinking, a key component of creativity.

The idea of needing 10,000 steps a day is likely exaggerated. This popular goal originated from a Japanese marketing campaign in the 1960s, rumored to be because the symbol in Japanese resembles [a person walking](#). However, recent research by the American Heart Association suggests health benefits can start [at 6,000 steps](#). The key takeaway is that any increase in daily movement, even below the steep goal of 10,000 steps, can still boost health and productivity.

Maybe we just need a Minimum Effective Dose (MED) of movement. Tim Ferriss's "The 4-Hour Body" emphasizes how we should focus on finding the smallest dose that produces the desired outcome - something like looking for the point of [diminishing returns](#) (sorry, I am an economist). He gives the example of how high-intensity interval training and [kettlebell swings](#) can be great MEDs for a full-body workout.

My Personal Thoughts

I started doubting the 10,000 steps-a-day goal after a trip to Disneyland with my family. We had barely reached 10,000 steps by 2 PM, and were already exhausted by then (or do steps count double if you are carrying a kid?)

I realized that setting such a high goal was counterproductive. Sometimes I felt that the goal was so unattainable that I just decided to start fresh the next day altogether, which is actually counterproductive. Maybe an MED goal of 6,000 would have been way better.

Systems > Goals. Instead of only setting a step goal, I have started to commit to daily habits such as walking 15 minutes after lunch or doing walking 1:1s.

[Side note: In my quest for a good MED, I found the exercise both LeBron James and Disney's CEO Bob Iger do - the [VersaClimber](#). It is kind of expensive, so I got [the cheaper version](#) and it lasted for 4 years]

How to Put This Into Practice

Science has proven that incorporating movement into daily routines can boost productivity. Try these steps:

1. **Set realistic goals:** Aim for a slightly higher daily step count and gradually increase it.
2. **Set the right systems:** Turn goals into daily habits, like walking after meals or having walking meetings.
3. **Pair movement with enjoyable activities:** As "Atomic Habits" suggests, link tasks that might not be appealing at first with enjoyable ones, like listening to a podcast or walking to your favorite coffee shop.
4. **Track progress:** You cannot improve what you cannot measure. Invest in a fitness tracker to monitor activity levels and celebrate milestones.

Effective Wisdom from the Andes: 5 Personal Growth Tips from the Incas

Related to last week's topic of distractions, I shared [this guide](#) for Microsoft Outlook, which you might find useful. This week, I planned to discuss internal distractions, but something hit me while celebrating Peruvian Independence Day, including enjoying some [chilcanos](#). We Peruvians adore our globally celebrated cuisine, with Lima having the most "World's Best 50" restaurants; yet, we seem less familiar with our [equally renowned](#) rich culture.

Similar to how I've explored concepts like [Ikigai](#) or [Dolce far niente](#), today I'm sharing Peruvian concepts that I believe are equally impactful. Here's a [visual summary](#) to share if you find it useful, and please comment if you think I missed anything.

The Theory

The Incas were ahead of their time, mastering topics from architecture (e.g., Machu Picchu) to advanced agricultural techniques (like terrace farming). Their societal organization was equally impressive and can serve as inspiration to enhance our personal and professional growth. I've highlighted four key concepts:

"Minka": Work for the greater good. Minka derives from the Quechua "minccacuni" meaning "asking for help by promising something." It emphasizes communal work for mutual benefit, demonstrating how solidarity and reciprocity were central to Inca society's effective functioning.

"Yachay": Always learning. Yachay (meaning wisdom and learning), promotes the continuous pursuit of knowledge and its thoughtful application, fostering a culture of intellectual growth.

"Wiñay": Focus on long-term impact and growth. Wiñay (meaning everlasting growth), emphasizes sustainability and endurance in everything we build and our personal well-being. [Side Note: The "Wiñay Wayna" section of the Inca Trail, translates to "Forever Young" and features vegetation such as ever-blooming orchids.]

"Sumak Kawsay": Embracing a Holistic Life. Literally translated as "Good Living," this concept goes beyond work-life balance to advocate harmony with nature and community, encouraging a lifestyle that supports personal, environmental, and community well-being.

My Personal Thoughts

These concepts parallel many global philosophies. Minka's focus on collective work parallels the African philosophy of [Ubuntu](#). Yachay's lifelong learning mirrors ancient Greek **philosophical inquiry**. Wiñay's long-term sustainability aligns with the Japanese principle of [Kaizen's](#) focus on continuous improvement. **Sumak Kawsay's** holistic approach is similar to the Scandinavian concept of [Lagom](#), emphasizing balance with a focus on communal and environmental harmony.

How to Put This Into Practice

1. **Adopting Minka:** We're often encouraged to "[say no](#)," but saying "yes" to collective needs is also really important. I recommend allocating about 15-25% of your workload to group-benefiting activities, but focusing on making your contributions visible.
2. **Adopting Yachay:** Dedicate regular time every week (or month) for continuous learning, treating it as a long-term investment. Set aside this time as an appointment with someone very important - your "future self."
3. **Adopting Wiñay:** When engaging in any project, adopt a long-term perspective. A bias for action combined with patience for results can create sustainable outcomes. Often, the projects that yield the best long-term results are the most challenging in the short term.
4. **Adopting Sumak Kawsay:** Set concrete goals for key areas that you consider part of your "Good Life" (e.g., health, well-being, relationships), and find accountability partners to help keep you on track.

I'm actually ashamed that I didn't know all this already. Once again, writing this newsletter has been a way to learn new concepts myself. I hope this offers you as much insight as it has given me. Thanks for exploring a bit more about my culture.

The Effective Corporate Athlete: Strategies for Professional Peak Performance

I spent (invested?) a lot of time watching the Olympics and was amazed by the strong demonstrations of sportsmanship and [Snoop Dogg's](#) dedication. This reminded me of a training I took over a decade ago that still resonates today. This training revolves around treating our corporate careers as if we were athletes. Popularized by the [Harvard Business Review](#), it offers valuable lessons on performance and resilience that are as relevant in climbing the corporate ladder as they are on the track.

The Theory

The Corporate Athlete theory proposes that professionals can achieve peak performance by training like athletes. Developed by two legends of the self-development field, Dr. Jim Loehr and Tony Schwartz, founders of the Human Performance Institute and The Energy Project, the theory emphasizes managing a [pyramid made up of four types of energy](#): physical, emotional, mental, and spiritual.

Physical energy is the foundation of the Corporate Athlete model. Just like athletes, corporate professionals need to maintain their physical health to perform optimally. This includes regular exercise, proper nutrition, and adequate sleep. A healthy body supports a healthy mind.

Emotional energy focuses on cultivating positive emotions and managing stress. Positive emotional energy can improve performance and teamwork, using techniques like mindfulness and gratitude practices. For instance, Emotional intelligence (EQ) is crucial as it enhances our ability to understand and manage our own emotions while effectively navigating and influencing the emotions of others.

Mental energy involves maintaining focus and clarity in the face of distractions. This includes setting clear goals, prioritizing tasks, and taking regular breaks to avoid mental fatigue. [Time-boxing](#) and [Taking Breaks](#) are two of the main techniques.

Spiritual energy relates to finding a deeper purpose and aligning actions with core values. This involves reflecting on personal mission, values, and the impact we wish to have in professional and personal lives.

Personal Thoughts

This concept, though 23 years old, becomes more relevant over time. It resonates with me because it emphasizes a holistic approach to peak performance. It's not just about working harder but about working smarter and taking care of all aspects of our well-being.

It's key to understand our natural energy levels and fluctuations to best integrate these four pillars. Knowing your energy cycles and implementing rituals like regular exercise, mental relaxation, and consistent sleep schedules is crucial for sustaining high performance in high-paced environments. [Here](#) is a previous article I wrote with a chronotype test you can take.

[HOW TO PUT THIS INTO PRACTICE](#)

As you probably realize, this theory incorporates many holistic topics. Here are a few practical tips to implement the Corporate Athlete theory:

1. **Prioritize physical health:** Measure your current exercise, diet, and sleep habits (e.g. you can use a [calorie-counting app](#)). First focus on just measuring it. Then, gradually (+5-10% at a time) work towards recommended levels for your age, gender, and height.
2. **Practice mindfulness:** Try sitting quietly for 5 minutes without any agenda, gradually increasing to 30 minutes. You will be surprised by what happens. Alternatively, start a [gratitude journal](#).
3. **Manage mental focus:** Break projects into smaller tasks and Time-block 90 minutes daily to the most important ones.
4. **Incorporate recovery rituals:** Take short, focused breaks throughout your workday to recharge. More info [here](#).
5. **Align with your purpose:** Reflect on your core values and why you work where you do. Write it down and remind yourself daily. [Side note: If your motivation is money, then it will probably not last for long, but it is still perfectly fine.]

The Corporate Athlete model provides a comprehensive framework for achieving high performance. By focusing on physical, emotional, mental, and spiritual energy, we can enhance our productivity and well-being, much like athletes train for their sports and reach the Olympics.

Effectively Energized: How to Create More Time by Doing the Right Work

In today's fast-paced world, finding the right balance between work and rest can make all the difference in how we manage our energy and stay effective. We've all heard the advice to "work less and accomplish more," (I actually [preach this myself](#)) but what if it's not about working less but working more on the things that energize us?

Today, we'll go a bit contrarian and explore how certain types of work can actually fuel you, and how you can apply this thinking to your own effectiveness.

The Theory

Energy management is more important than time management. The concept of "[Drainers and Batteries](#)" revolves around identifying tasks that either exhaust our energy (drainers) or recharge us (batteries). While it's difficult to figure out exactly who created this concept, this idea has evolved from the broader field of energy management that was popularized by Jim Loehr's [The Power of Full Engagement](#). The key takeaway here is that we often focus on managing time when we should be managing our energy. By doing tasks that recharge us, we can accomplish more without feeling burnt out. Drainers pull us down; batteries lift us up - knowing the difference is essential for sustained productivity.

Working in our zone of genius puts us in a state of flow. The concept of the "[Zone of Genius](#)" refers to the work we are naturally skilled at and love doing. Similarly, the theory of "[flow](#)" describes a state of optimal experience where we're fully immersed and enjoying our work. Both concepts point to the idea that when we align our work with our strengths and interests, it doesn't feel like work at all - it energizes us. This is where the reason behind the idea that working *more* (on the right things) can actually be more energizing than working *less* overall.

Hustle culture emphasizes working harder, but restorative activities help us recharge. Hustle culture promotes the idea that working endlessly will eventually lead to success. However, even with things we are passionate about, this could also lead to burnout, as people can push themselves beyond their natural energy limits. The concept of restorative activities suggests that intentional breaks and restful periods allow us to recharge, leading to better long-term performance. This doesn't mean we need to be working less necessarily, but working in cycles that allow us to restore our mental and emotional energy. So, again, it's not always about working fewer hours overall - it's about knowing when to push and when to rest.

My Own Thoughts

When I discovered that training others energized me, I realized that some work can actually give you more energy than it takes. At one point, I was spending just two hours a week mentoring and training others, but I felt like I was getting more than those two hours back. I would wake up before my family and start my day feeling productive, as if I was creating extra time. This idea of finding work that refuels you, even as you do it, is fascinating - could it be possible that certain tasks “give back” more than they consume? I sometimes think so. [Side note: BTW, I am currently training teams full-time, so just reply to this message if you want to see my passion in motion - more details in the PS section of this email]

I believe it's not just about "eating the frog" - sometimes it's about "finding the frog." When we focus on tasks that align with our intrinsic motivations (what we want to do) rather than extrinsic motivations (what we think we *should* do), we tap into a source of energy that goes beyond the task itself. By finding the right “frog,” we can work more effectively and feel more energized doing it. It's about aligning your work with your natural sources of motivation, those that give you energy.

How to Put This into Practice:

1. **Identify Your Drainers and Batteries:** Make a list of tasks that deplete your energy and those that recharge it. This awareness is the first step to optimizing your energy.
2. **Find the Frog, Don't Just Eat It:** Identify the most impactful tasks that also energize you, rather than simply tackling the hardest task first.
3. **Start Tasting the Frog:** Force yourself to dedicate time to work that combines your skills and passions, where you lose track of time and feel energized. ([Tips here](#) on how to force yourself to find the time).
4. **Build in Restorative Breaks:** Take [this test](#) to ensure you know what is your chronotype and then schedule when it is best to take breaks to recharge.

Effective Gratitude: Gratitude Isn't Just for the Holidays

I'm writing this from Zion National Park, and I honestly can't decide what amazes me more: the amazing beauty of America's national parks or the fact that my 4- and 7-year-old sons walked 8 miles (13 kilometers) today without a major complaint. [As some of you know](#), nature walking was a family goal for my wife and me this year, and seeing our short weekly hikes compound into full-day national park adventures is incredibly rewarding.

Today, I'm thankful for us making that commitment to be more in touch with nature. Whether or not you're celebrating Thanksgiving, this time of year is perfect for reflecting on the people and moments that shaped your journey (coworkers, friends, or family). It's an opportunity to strengthen connections and end the year on a positive note.

The Theory

Gratitude improves relationships and collaboration. [Research by Adam Grant](#) shows that expressing gratitude in the workplace builds trust and boosts engagement. A simple "thank you" can significantly increase a person's willingness to collaborate, creating a cycle of positivity and productivity.

Gratitude rewires the brain. Neuroscience research reveals that practicing gratitude can literally change [how our brains function](#). Regularly focusing on what we're thankful for strengthens neural pathways associated with positivity and resilience, making it easier to stay optimistic in tough times. [Side note: Even if you don't believe this, it's a pretty low-risk experiment to just give it a try!]

It benefits the giver and the receiver. Gratitude isn't just one-sided. Studies show that both expressing and receiving thanks enhance well-being and mood. [For the giver](#), it's an opportunity to reflect and grow. For the receiver, it's a confidence boost and a reminder of their value. Gratitude is a win-win for our teams and our own minds.

My Personal Thoughts

I'm incredibly grateful for you reading this right now. Writing this newsletter wasn't part of a grand plan. It started as an experiment and has grown into something deeply meaningful. Knowing that these insights resonate with you, spark discussions, and even inspire actions in your life is more fulfilling than I can put into words. [Side note: You're always welcome to reply to this newsletter and connect with me directly. I really enjoy reading questions and anecdotes!]

As we approach the end of the year, I encourage you to take a moment to reflect on your own gratitude. Whether it's someone who helped you succeed at work, a friend who supported you, or the small joys that made a difference on tough days, there's always something to be thankful for.

How to Put This Into Practice

1. **Celebrate your wins.** Take a moment to reflect on what you've accomplished this year. [Gratitude starts with yourself](#), so acknowledge your hard work and progress, no matter how big or small. Treat yourself to something you enjoy. It's a well-deserved reward.
2. **Send a personalized thank-you.** Think of someone who supported or inspired you this year and write them a genuine thank-you note. Be specific about why you're grateful, it adds a personal touch. Bonus points if you write it by hand.
3. **Share public recognition.** Gratitude can be contagious. Take a moment in a meeting or team chat to thank a colleague for their contributions. Highlighting someone's efforts can boost morale and strengthen connections.
4. **Connect with someone meaningfully.** Share your Thanksgiving traditions with someone from a different culture or take this opportunity to thank someone you've worked closely with as the year winds down. It's a simple yet powerful way to build connections.
5. **Offer a small token of appreciation.** A thoughtful gift, no matter how small, can make someone's day. One of my favorites to give out is this [Mug from Anthropologie](#) [Side note: Last year, hundreds of you loved this idea, and I can confirm... it's still a hit!]



OTHER

Effectively leaving Amazon: Today is my last day

Today is my last day at Amazon after 7 years and 10 months, or 2,867 Day 1's, as some say. I have mixed feelings, but I am mostly filled with gratitude. As you probably know, I am passionate about learning, and I am thankful for the opportunity to learn from a company that many find inspiring.

I have summarized my main learnings below in a way that can be applicable to anyone in any company. I hope you find it useful.

7 Learnings from 7+ years at Amazon

1. **"Ruthlessly Prioritize":** When I joined Amazon in 2016, I asked everyone I met for their #1 tip, and most said this. "Ruthlessly" means "without pity or compassion for others" so initially I was worried; however, as I found the environment to be mostly friendly and collaborative, I realized that it's about being "ruthless" towards our other priorities. We need to focus on prioritizing some task and leave others behind, even if it's hard, to succeed in a high-paced environment.
2. **The Power of a Well-Written Doc:** At Amazon, new roles are being created all the time, and I have been approached by many who think their job is pointless. I've seen them take four routes: (1) Complain to others, (2) Shut up and do as they're told, (3) Leave their team, (4) Demonstrate why they shouldn't do what they're told and suggest an alternative. Aim for #4. Write a 1-2 page document with data and anecdotes explaining why you should pivot and how it will benefit the team. Circulate it, get buy-in, and present it to the decision-maker. If it doesn't work, consider #3, but **never** do #1 or #2.
3. **Work Backwards from Personal Goals:** Like Amazon works backwards from business objectives, do the same with personal goals. For example, if you want a promotion, understand the process, the required documentation, and who makes the decisions. Then, work backwards to meet those requirements. For instance, you can get exposure to people that are part of the decision committee and ask them what they think your "best reason not to promote" (a part of the process) is, then address proactively.
4. **Have a Sounding Board:** Beyond having a mentor or sponsor, benefit from a peer sounding board. This person can be within or outside your team, someone you can be vulnerable and authentic with, share ideas, get an external perspective, or sometimes just get it off your chest in order to then address matters calmly.
5. **Focus on Mechanisms:** Several leaders I have met often credit mechanisms for Amazon's success. Mechanisms transform inputs into outputs (e.g., Weekly Business Review). Mechanisms have multiple parts (you can [view them here](#)). My main learning is that most of us have the opportunity to focus more on our mechanisms both at work and personal lives. Most people mistake outputs for inputs (e.g. my goal in 2024 is to lose 10 kg/lbs - that's an output). Many set the wrong incentives and don't encourage adoption (what is referred to as "make it attractive" in Atomic Habits). Focus your energy and time in setting the right

mechanisms / systems for your desired goals - "You don't rise to the level of your goals. You fall to the level of your systems."

6. **Being Dispensable vs. Indispensable:** While being dispensable is risky (especially as we enter the "Age of AI"), being indispensable also limits career progression, and I have seen it time and time again with very talented employees. It's hard to give new opportunities to indispensable people because no one else can do what they do. Empower and train others if you're an individual contributor. If you're a manager, develop your team members to be your successors. If you are busy all the time and only you can do certain tasks, then you are not scalable and will likely remain where you are.
7. **Don't reveal 100% of what you know:** This is extremely important as we

My personal thoughts

I hope you all got my joke with #7 haha. My #7 tip is actually to "Be yourself". It's hard when you're different inside and outside of work. I actually like telling jokes (good or bad) and believe these [do have an impact](#) on our work, mostly by earning trust. There was a time when I thought that being myself at work wasn't "professional," but you know what? being someone else is exhausting.

Wondering what's next for me? I'll announce it soon, but it involves creating new ways to share content that I've seen help many others. Please use the referral link below to recommend this newsletter so others can also stay tuned. [You can consider this as giving me a first push]

Effective Birthday Reflections: 18 Things I Learned about Personal Growth

On Self-Development

1. **Don't compare yourself to others - especially online.** For example, today I'm turning 39. See how easy it was to lie? (ha!) Everyone curates a filtered version of their lives online. Social media is a highlight reel, not the whole story. Instead of comparing ourselves to others, let's focus on our own growth and reality. Authenticity beats comparison every time.
2. **Pain is knowledge hitting hard.** Imagine stubbing your toe - it hurts because it's a valuable lesson hitting your brain hard. Remember Michael Jordan's words: "Learning is a gift, even when pain is your teacher." Let's embrace the lessons pain brings.
3. **To become a kinder person, start by doing kind things.** Behavioral Theory suggests our actions shape our character. For example, "doing kind things" doesn't come naturally to me, but I want to be kinder, so I started taking action, even when it felt unnatural (like offering to take pictures for those struggling with selfies at Yellowstone today). As Aristotle said, "We are what we repeatedly do," so maybe one day I'll become a nice person.
4. **We can do it all! (Just not all at once).** Success requires prioritization. I see a lot of people wanting to make money, but also have good work-life balance, and also work on something with a purpose. We can aim to achieve all of these things, but probably not everything at the same time. Focus on what's most important now, and give it your all. Play the long game.

On Life Decisions

5. **Living abroad boosts personal growth.** In my experience, there's nothing like living in another country. It challenges our worldview, helps us appreciate other cultures, and broadens our understanding of humanity. With time, I realized a lot of the things people eagerly discuss (and fight) about are all highly correlated to where they were born, so experiencing other realities can also be humbling.
6. **Marry Someone You Admire.** The person you marry will be one of the biggest decisions impacting your life. Careers, parenting, finances, and health - all will have their challenges. Choose someone you deeply admire - someone whose character, values, and outlook inspire you to become a better person. The rest will figure itself out.
7. **"Most people overestimate what they can do in one year and underestimate what they can do in ten years."** The hardest challenges often bring the greatest rewards, but long-term growth requires patience and overcoming short-term discomfort. In a world of instant gratification, be the one who persists, even when progress is slow or invisible - because the most worthwhile results come from consistent effort over time.

On Continuous Learning

8. **We can't master all essential skills - Seek experts.** In a complex world, focus on mastering a few essential skills. For the rest, seek help from experts. This approach will save you time and enhance your results. The most important skills I see repeatedly needing expert support are: personal finances, nutrition, strength training, parenting, time management, and communication.
9. **The best way to learn is to teach.** The best way to deepen our understanding is to teach others. Don't shy away from sharing your knowledge, even if no one's watching/reading. The best way to excel at something is trying to explain it simply to others (h/t The Feynman Technique).
10. **Master search skills.** In a world overflowing with information, knowing how to search effectively is invaluable. Mastering the art of finding the right information can save time and open new opportunities. What used to be "Googling" is now all about "prompting."
11. **Do the Right Things, Not Just Things Right.** As Peter Drucker famously said, "There is nothing so useless as doing efficiently that which should not be done at all." In an era where everyone is seeking optimization, make sure your efforts align with your goals beforehand.

On Smart Spending

12. **Justify something expensive by calculating its cost per use.** When considering a big purchase, think about the cost per use. If you'd rent it for that amount, it's likely worth the investment. On that note, expenses related to having a good night's rest are usually worth it as we spend a third of our lives sleeping. Invest in that fancy mattress and pillow!
13. **Match spending with your values.** Our money and time spent should reflect what matters most to us. I always said that personal growth was a priority, but struggled to pay for courses and coaching. Now, I set a percentage of my time and budget to be spent on my values in advance to avoid this. Measure how much of your budget (time and money) aligns with what you value the most.
14. **Dollar Cost Averaging and Compound Interest Are Keys to Wealth.** Wealth-building isn't about quick wins but consistent, disciplined (sometimes boring) investing. [Dollar cost averaging](#) and compound interest apply not just to money but to skills and reputation too.

On Influencing Others

15. **Proactively shape others.** I once read something that stuck "We often overestimate our influence on our own children and underestimate our impact on younger colleagues." Our actions leave a lasting mark, so don't wait to be asked - reach out to mentor others. They'll appreciate it, and you will fill your bucket.

16. **Everyone's Figuring It Out.** No one has all the answers, so when dealing with uncertainty, present leaders with options, pros and cons, and an informed proposal. Remember, everyone's learning as they go, make the decision-making process intuitive.
17. **The power of communicating in threes.** To communicate effectively, limit your points to three. Whether you're making a case in favor of something or want to highlight key accomplishments, three is the magic number for clarity and impact. Two is too little, and four is usually too many.
18. **Be extra kind to service workers.** It's easy to take service workers for granted. Practice empathy and kindness especially with them - small gestures make a big difference in their day. If you haven't worked in a service job, consider giving your kids that experience.

This list is the result of consuming, aggregating, and reflecting on a lot of content. I'm intentionally not calling this the list of "things I wish I knew 10 years ago." I don't wish that. Every lesson learned, even the hard ones, has been invaluable. Without those experiences, I wouldn't be here writing this now. [Side note: Candidly, maybe #14 on dollar cost averaging is something I wish I knew before]. Cheers to another year of growth!

Effectively Listening in 2024: My Top 10 Podcast Episodes

Every now and then, I like to break the usual structure of this newsletter for a special occasion. Whether you're wrapping up your work deliverables or resting on your couch, the next couple of weeks are rarely "regular" days.

2024 was a year of transition for me - I wrote more than ever and leaned heavily into audio content, clocking over 30,000 minutes of listening. But I didn't do it alone.

Some of the podcast episodes on this list were actually recommendations from you, the readers of this newsletter. So, as we close out the year, I'm breaking the mold to share two lists: my **Top 10 Podcast Episodes of 2024** and the **Top 10 Most-Clicked Links** from this newsletter (coming next week).

As always, if something here resonates (or you just want to say hi) hit reply. I always enjoy hearing from you.

Top 10 podcast episodes:

[Pro tip: Listening to all these episodes is a big time investment. Start by checking out the [playlist here](#). If you find any of these on YouTube, you can paste the link into this [CustomGPT](#) to get a quick summary. Then decide which ones deserve your full attention.]

1. **"How to Embrace Slow Productivity, Build a Deep Life, Achieve Mastery, and Defend Your Time" (*The Tim Ferriss Show, Guest: Cal Newport*)**
 - o Main Takeaways: They explore slow productivity and building a meaningful life by prioritizing high-impact tasks, values alignment, and meaningful relationships. Shares strategies to protect time through focused practice, time-blocking, and minimizing distractions.
2. **"The Infinite Game with Dr. James Carse" (*A Bit of Optimism, Guest: Dr. James Carse*)**
 - o Main Takeaways: Adopting an infinite mindset encourages organizations to focus on long-term value and resilience rather than short-term victories. Leaders who embrace this perspective prioritize trust, innovation, and sustainable success.
3. **"Rules of the Money Game" (*The Morgan Housel Podcast*)**
 1. Main Takeaways: Housel shares 30 key principles of personal finance, focusing on behavior and psychology over technical knowledge. Highlights the importance of managing emotions and biases to make better financial decisions.
4. **"How to Love Criticism" (*WorkLife with Adam Grant*)**
 1. Main Takeaways: Viewing criticism as a tool for improvement rather than a personal attack creates a growth-oriented mindset. Creating environments where feedback is openly exchanged enhances team dynamics and individual performance.

5. **"You 2.0: The Gift of Other People" (*Hidden Brain*, Guest: Nicholas Epley)**
 1. Main Takeaways: Engaging in conversations with strangers can lead to unexpectedly positive experiences. Overcoming the reluctance to initiate interactions actually improves well-being.
6. **"The Attention Graph" (*The Prof G Pod with Scott Galloway*, Guest: Dr. Jennifer Aaker and Naomi Bagdonas)**
 1. Main Takeaways: Humor, when used appropriately, can enhance leadership effectiveness and team cohesion. Understanding the dynamics of attention in the digital age is crucial for effective communication and influence.
7. **"Tony Robbins Changes My Life (48 Minute Coaching Session)" (*My First Million*, Guest: Tony Robbins)**
 1. Main Takeaways: Robbins shares strategies for overcoming limiting beliefs and cultivating a mindset geared toward personal and professional growth. He also shared techniques to achieve peak performance.
8. **"Elizabeth Gilbert | The Simple Practice That Changed Her Life (and might change yours)" (*Good Life Project*, Guest: Elizabeth Gilbert)**
 1. Main Takeaways: Elizabeth Gilbert shares a writing practice starting with "Dear Love," building self-compassion and self-awareness. Quieting the inner critic enables authentic self-expression and personal growth.
9. **"Transform Your Life: How One More Can Change Everything" (*The Ed Mylett Show*)**
 1. Main Takeaways: Small, consistent actions like doing "one more" rep, call, or act of kindness can lead to extraordinary outcomes. By committing to "one more," you cultivate discipline, resilience, and the ability to push past perceived limits.
10. **"Be a Better Leader, the Human Paradox, and the Folly of a Plan" (*The Prof G Pod with Scott Galloway*, Guest: Simon Sinek)**
 1. Main Takeaways: Sinek explores leadership strategies, emphasizing mentorship and meaningful relationship-building. Highlights the power of storytelling to inspire and create deeper connections.